# The Biblical Story Through Its Main Characters

**PLANTED YOUTH**

**Millheim Baptist Church**

# Introduction

The Bible tells one connected history through real people and events. These lessons follow the major characters and stories from Lucifer's rebellion and Adam's fall through Israel's patriarchs, kings, and prophets; Jesus Christ and His apostles; the Church's mission; and Christ's return and eternal kingdom.

Read the listed passages, fill in the blanks as you go through each section, look up the verses, and use the charts to connect each person and event with the whole story.

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UNIT 1 — REBELLION, RECONSTRUCTION, AND THE FIRST WORLD

# Lesson 1 — Lucifer: The First Rebel and the Ruined Earth

**Lesson Overview:** The Bible's story begins with God, His original creation, and a created cherub who becomes proud. Lucifer's rebellion brings judgment and darkness; God then speaks light, order, and life into the ruined earth.

**MAIN PASSAGES:** Genesis 1:1–2:3; Job 38:4–7; Isaiah 14:12–15; Ezekiel 28:12–19; Isaiah 45:18

**KEY VERSE | Ezekiel 28:15 —** *Thou wast perfect in thy ways from the day that thou wast created, till iniquity was found in thee.*

**READ:** Genesis 1:1–2:3; Job 38:4–7; Isaiah 14:12–15; 45:18; Ezekiel 28:12–19; John 1:1–5; Revelation 12:7–12.

## The Story in Scripture

| Story movement | Scripture |
|---|---|
| God creates the heaven and the earth | Genesis 1:1 — ***"In the beginning God created the heaven and the earth."*** |
| The heavenly host rejoices | Job 38:4–7 describes the morning stars singing and the sons of God shouting at the earth's foundation. |
| Pride rises in Lucifer | Isaiah 14:12–15 records his five proud ***"I will"*** statements. |
| Iniquity is found in the cherub | Ezekiel 28:12–17 describes beauty, wisdom, pride, and corruption. |

| Story movement | Scripture |
| --- | --- |
| The earth lies under darkness | Genesis 1:2; compare Isaiah 45:18 and Jeremiah 4:23–26. |
| God begins reconstruction | Genesis 1:3 — ***"And God said, Let there be light: and there was light."*** |

## 1. Lucifer's Position, Pride, and Fall

Lucifer is a created **cherub**, not God's equal. Ezekiel describes an anointed cherub who was perfect in his ways until iniquity was found in him. Isaiah records five "I will" statements as his heart was lifted up in **pride** and he tried to be like the most High.

- Before God ever made man, He had already created the angels. The "morning stars" and "sons of God" shouted for joy when He laid the foundations of the earth (Job 38:4–7).
- Lucifer was one of the highest of these created beings, but he wanted God's throne for himself.
- His rebellion starts the conflict that runs through the whole Bible: God moves history toward His purpose, while Satan opposes God's Word, God's people, God's land, and God's promised King.

**Isaiah 14:13–14 —** *For thou hast said in thine heart, I will ascend into heaven, I will exalt my throne above the stars of God: I will sit also upon the mount of the congregation, in the sides of the north: I will ascend above the heights of the clouds; I will be like the most High.*

**Ezekiel 28:17 —** *Thine heart was lifted up because of thy beauty, thou hast corrupted thy wisdom by reason of thy brightness: I will cast thee to the ground…*

### Lucifer's Fall

| Stage | What Scripture shows | Passages |
|---|---|---|
| Created | Perfect in his ways; wise, beautiful, and appointed as an anointed cherub | Ezekiel 28:12–15 |
| Proud | His heart is lifted up because of beauty | Ezekiel 28:17 |
| Rebellious | He seeks a higher throne and God's place | Isaiah 14:12–14 |
| Cast down | God announces humiliation and judgment | Isaiah 14:15; Ezekiel 28:16–19 |
| Still opposing | He deceives, accuses, and fights until his final judgment | Genesis 3; Revelation 12:9–12; 20:10 |

## 2. God Reconstructs the Earth

Genesis 1:1 records God's original creation. By Genesis 1:2 the earth is without form, void, and covered in **darkness**. Beginning in verse 3, God speaks **light** into the darkness and restores order day by day, preparing the earth for mankind. On the sixth day He makes man in His own **image**.

- God did not create the earth ruined. Isaiah 45:18 says He "created it not in vain" (the word "vain" is the same Hebrew word translated "without form" in Genesis 1:2).
- Jeremiah 4:23–26 uses the same words, "without form, and void," to describe a land under God's judgment.
- The six days prepare the ruined earth as a home for Adam. The next lesson picks up the story in the garden of Eden.

> **Genesis 1:2–3 —** *And the earth was without form, and void; and darkness was upon the face of the deep. And the Spirit of God moved upon the face of the waters. And God said, Let there be light: and there was light.*

**Isaiah 45:18 —** *...God himself that formed the earth and made it; he hath established it, he created it not in vain, he formed it to be inhabited...*

### The Days of Reconstruction

| Day | God's work | Scripture |
|---|---|---|
| 1 | Light divided from darkness | Genesis 1:3–5 |
| 2 | Firmament divides the waters | Genesis 1:6–8 |
| 3 | Dry land, seas, grass, herbs, and fruit trees | Genesis 1:9–13 |
| 4 | Sun, moon, and stars appointed | Genesis 1:14–19 |
| 5 | Sea creatures and flying creatures | Genesis 1:20–23 |
| 6 | Land animals; man and woman | Genesis 1:24–31; 2:7, 18–25 |
| 7 | God rests from His finished work | Genesis 2:1–3 |

## Check Your Understanding

1. What does Scripture reveal about Lucifer before his rebellion?
2. What five proud desires appear in Isaiah 14:12–14?
3. How does Satan oppose God's purpose throughout the Bible?
4. What condition does Genesis 1:2 describe?
5. List the days of reconstruction and their passages.

UNIT 1 — REBELLION, RECONSTRUCTION, AND THE FIRST WORLD

# Lesson 2 — Adam and Eve: Eden, the Fall, and the Promised Seed

**Lesson Overview:** God places Adam and Eve in Eden with life, fellowship, work, marriage, and dominion. The serpent attacks God's Word; Adam disobeys; sin and death enter; and God promises the Seed who will defeat the serpent.

**MAIN PASSAGES:** Genesis 1:26–31; Genesis 2–3; Romans 5:12–21; 1 Timothy 2:13–14; Revelation 12:9

**KEY VERSE | Genesis 3:15 —** *And I will put enmity between thee and the woman, and between thy seed and her seed; it shall bruise thy head, and thou shalt bruise his heel.*

**READ:** Genesis 1:26–31; 2:7–25; 3:1–24; Romans 5:12–21; 1 Corinthians 15:21–22, 45–49; 1 Timothy 2:13–14; Revelation 12:9.

## The Story in Scripture

| Story movement | Scripture |
|---|---|
| God forms Adam | Genesis 2:7 — God forms man from dust and breathes into him the breath of life. |
| God forms Eve | Genesis 2:18–25 — God makes a help meet for Adam and establishes marriage. |
| The serpent attacks the Word | Genesis 3:1–5 — he questions, contradicts, and changes God's command. |
| Adam and Eve eat | Genesis 3:6–7 — shame and separation immediately follow. |

| Story movement | Scripture |
|---|---|
| God pronounces judgment | Genesis 3:14–19 — the serpent, woman, man, and ground are addressed. |
| God promises the Seed | Genesis 3:15 points forward to the serpent's defeat. |

## 1. Life in Eden

God forms Adam from the dust of the ground and breathes into him the breath of life. Adam is made in God's image and receives dominion under God. God puts him in the garden to dress it and to **keep** it, gives him one clear command, and makes Eve as an help **meet** for him. Marriage begins as one man and one woman joined by God.

- Remember, God had just prepared the earth in six days (Lesson 1). Now He places man at the center of His restored creation.
- Eden had everything Adam needed: food, work, fellowship with God, and a wife.
- There was only one restriction, the tree of the knowledge of good and evil, so obeying God was simple.

> **Genesis 2:15 —** *And the LORD God took the man, and put him into the garden of Eden to dress it and to keep it.*
>
> **Genesis 2:16–17 —** *...Of every tree of the garden thou mayest freely eat: But of the tree of the knowledge of good and evil, thou shalt not eat of it: for in the day that thou eatest thereof thou shalt surely die.*

## 2. The First Attack on God's Word

The serpent's first recorded attack is aimed at what God **said**. He questions, contradicts, and changes God's Word. Eve is deceived, but Adam knowingly disobeys. Through one man, sin and **death** enter the world.

- The serpent is Satan himself, the same proud rebel from Lesson 1 (Revelation 12:9).

- Satan could not take God's throne, so he attacked God's newest creation, man, by attacking God's Word.
- Eve also added to God's Word ("neither shall ye touch it"). Changing God's Word, by adding to it or taking away from it, always leads to trouble.

**Genesis 3:1 —** *Now the serpent was more subtil than any beast of the field which the LORD God had made. And he said unto the woman, Yea, hath God said, Ye shall not eat of every tree of the garden?*

**Romans 5:12 —** *Wherefore, as by one man sin entered into the world, and death by sin; and so death passed upon all men, for that all have sinned:*

### The Serpent's Strategy

| Attack | Words or action | What changed |
|---|---|---|
| Questions | ***"Yea, hath God said...?"*** (Genesis 3:1) | Doubt is introduced. |
| Contradicts | ***"Ye shall not surely die"*** (Genesis 3:4) | God's warning is denied. |
| Changes | Disobedience is presented as advancement (Genesis 3:5) | A false promise replaces God's truth. |
| Eve adds | ***"neither shall ye touch it"*** (Genesis 3:3) | Words not in Genesis 2:16–17 are added. |

## 3. Judgment and the First Promise

God seeks the guilty pair, exposes their sin, and pronounces judgment. Yet judgment is not the last word. God promises that the **Seed** of the woman will be wounded, but He will crush the serpent's head. The rest of the Bible follows this promise to Jesus Christ, who is called the last **Adam**.

- Genesis 3:15 is the first promise of a Saviour in the Bible.
- God clothed Adam and Eve with coats of skins (Genesis 3:21). An animal died to cover their shame, a first picture of sacrifice.
- From here on, the story follows the line of the promised Seed through Seth, Noah, Abraham, Israel, and David until Christ is born. Satan will keep trying to destroy that line.

**Romans 5:19 —** *For as by one man's disobedience many were made sinners, so by the obedience of one shall many be made righteous.*

**1 Corinthians 15:45 —** *And so it is written, The first man Adam was made a living soul; the last Adam was made a quickening spirit.*

## Check Your Understanding

1. What responsibilities did God give Adam in Eden?
2. How did the serpent attack God's Word?
3. How does 1 Timothy 2 distinguish Eve's deception from Adam's transgression?
4. What entered the world through Adam's sin?
5. How does Genesis 3:15 direct the story toward Christ?

UNIT 1 — REBELLION, RECONSTRUCTION, AND THE FIRST WORLD

# Lesson 3 — Cain, Abel, Enoch, and Noah: Sin Spreads and God Preserves

**Lesson Overview:** Outside Eden, sin spreads through Adam's family and fills the earth with violence. Abel worships by faith, Enoch walks with God, and Noah finds grace. God judges the world through the Flood while preserving Noah's household in the ark.

**MAIN PASSAGES:** Genesis 4–9; Hebrews 11:4–7; Matthew 24:37–39; 1 Peter 3:20; 2 Peter 2:5

**KEY VERSE | Genesis 6:8 —** *But Noah found grace in the eyes of the LORD.*

**READ:** Genesis 4:1–16; 5:1–32; 6:1–9:29; Hebrews 11:4–7; Matthew 24:37–39; 1 Peter 3:18–22; 2 Peter 2:5; 3:3–7.

## The Story in Scripture

| Story movement | Scripture |
|---|---|
| Abel offers by faith | Genesis 4:1–5; Hebrews 11:4. |
| Cain murders Abel | Genesis 4:6–16 — Cain ignores God's warning that sin lies at the door. |
| Enoch walks with God | Genesis 5:21–24; Hebrews 11:5–6. |
| The earth becomes corrupt | Genesis 6:5, 11–13. |
| Noah builds the ark | Genesis 6:14–22; Hebrews 11:7. |

| Story movement | Scripture |
|---|---|
| The Flood judges the world | Genesis 7:1–24. |
| God gives the rainbow | Genesis 8:20–9:17. |

## 1. Three Men in a Fallen World

Outside Eden, sin spreads to the next generation. Abel offers unto God by **faith**, but Cain refuses God's warning and kills his brother. Later, Enoch walks with **God** in a wicked generation and is taken to heaven without dying.

- Remember, God promised a Seed from the woman (Genesis 3:15). When Abel is murdered, Satan is attacking the family line of that promise.
- God gives Adam and Eve another son, Seth, and the line of promise continues through him (Genesis 4:25).
- Genesis 5 repeats "and he died" again and again. Sin's penalty had come just as God said. Enoch is the one exception.

> **Hebrews 11:4 —** *By faith Abel offered unto God a more excellent sacrifice than Cain, by which he obtained witness that he was righteous, God testifying of his gifts: and by it he being dead yet speaketh.*
>
> **Genesis 5:24 —** *And Enoch walked with God: and he was not; for God took him.*

### Cain, Abel, and Enoch

| Person | Choice | Result | Passages |
|---|---|---|---|
| Abel | Offers to God by faith | Receives witness that he is righteous | Genesis 4:2–5; Hebrews 11:4 |

| Person | Choice | Result | Passages |
|---|---|---|---|
| Cain | Rejects warning and murders Abel | Is judged and becomes a fugitive | Genesis 4:5–16; 1 John 3:11–12 |
| Enoch | Walks with God by faith | Is translated without seeing death | Genesis 5:21–24; Hebrews 11:5–6; Jude 14–15 |

## 2. Noah, the Ark, and the Flood

The earth becomes corrupt and filled with violence. Noah finds **grace** in the eyes of the LORD, believes God's warning, and builds the ark. The Flood judges the old world, while the ark preserves Noah's family, **eight** souls in all. Afterward God sets the **rainbow** in the cloud as the sign of His covenant with the earth.

- Noah comes from the line of Seth, so the line of promise continues through him (Genesis 5:28–32).
- If all mankind had been destroyed, there would be no Seed to crush the serpent. God preserved one family so His promise would stand.
- Jesus said the days before His return will be like the days of Noah (Matthew 24:37).

> **Genesis 6:5 —** *And GOD saw that the wickedness of man was great in the earth, and that every imagination of the thoughts of his heart was only evil continually.*
>
> **Genesis 9:13 —** *I do set my bow in the cloud, and it shall be for a token of a covenant between me and the earth.*

### Noah's Story

| Movement | What happened | Scripture |
|---|---|---|
| Grace | Noah finds grace and walks with God | Genesis 6:8–9 |

| Movement | What happened | Scripture |
|---|---|---|
| Warning | God announces judgment and gives the ark's plan | Genesis 6:11–22 |
| Obedience | Noah enters with his family and the animals | Genesis 7:1–10 |
| Judgment | The Flood covers the earth | Genesis 7:11–24 |
| Preservation | God remembers Noah; the waters recede | Genesis 8:1–19 |
| Covenant | God gives the rainbow sign | Genesis 8:20–9:17 |

## Check Your Understanding

1. How did Abel, Cain, and Enoch respond differently to God?
2. What does the repeated phrase “and he died” teach in Genesis 5?
3. Why did God send the Flood?
4. How did Noah demonstrate faith?
5. What did God promise in the Noahic covenant?

UNIT 1 — REBELLION, RECONSTRUCTION, AND THE FIRST WORLD

# Lesson 4 — Babel and Abraham: The Nations Scatter and One Man Is Called

**Lesson Overview:** At Babel mankind unites in pride, builds a city and tower, and seeks to reach God on their own. God scatters the nations, then calls Abram from Ur and promises to form a nation through which all families of the earth will be blessed.

**MAIN PASSAGES:** Genesis 10–12; Genesis 15; Genesis 17; Genesis 22; Galatians 3:6–18

**KEY VERSE | Genesis 12:2–3 —** *And I will make of thee a great nation, and I will bless thee, and make thy name great…and in thee shall all families of the earth be blessed.*

**READ:** Genesis 10:1–32; 11:1–32; 12:1–9; 13:14–18; 15:1–21; 17:1–21; 22:1–18; Romans 4:1–5; Galatians 3:6–18.

## The Story in Scripture

| Story movement | Scripture |
|---|---|
| Families become nations | Genesis 10 traces the descendants of Shem, Ham, and Japheth; the sons of Noah. |
| Men build Babel | Genesis 11:1–4 — they seek a city, tower, and name. |
| God scatters mankind | Genesis 11:5–9 — languages are confounded. |
| God calls Abram | Genesis 12:1–3 — land, nation, name, and worldwide blessing are promised to Abram. |
| Abram believes God | Genesis 15:6 — faith is counted for righteousness to Abram. This set a biblical pattern for us. |

| Story movement | Scripture |
| --- | --- |
| The covenant is confirmed | Genesis 15; 17; 22. |

## 1. Babel: Man's Name and God's Judgment

After the Flood, God tells Noah's sons to replenish the earth. Instead, at Babel mankind stays together, builds a city and a tower that reaches toward heaven, and tries to make themselves a **name**. God confounds their **language** and scatters them across the earth.

- Remember, God told Noah's family to "replenish the earth" (Genesis 9:1). Babel was open disobedience.
- This is the same pride we saw in Lucifer. "I will ascend into heaven" (Isaiah 14:13) becomes "let us build us… a tower, whose top may reach unto heaven."
- Genesis 10 lists the nations that came from Noah's three sons. These are the "nations" the rest of the Bible talks about.

> **Genesis 11:4 —** *And they said, Go to, let us build us a city and a tower, whose top may reach unto heaven; and let us make us a name, lest we be scattered abroad upon the face of the whole earth.*
>
> **Genesis 11:9 —** *Therefore is the name of it called Babel; because the LORD did there confound the language of all the earth: and from thence did the LORD scatter them abroad upon the face of all the earth.*

## 2. Abraham: God's Name and God's Promise

God answers the pride of the nations by calling one man. Abram leaves **Ur** of the Chaldees at God's word. God promises him **land**, seed, and blessing, and through his seed all families of the earth will be blessed. Abraham believed God, and it was counted to him for **righteousness**.

- The nations turned from God at Babel. Now God starts a new nation from one man, and that nation will become Israel.
- The promised Seed from Genesis 3:15 will come through Abraham's family (Galatians 3:16).
- Abraham is not perfect, and his failures are recorded. But God keeps His covenant, and Abraham's faith becomes the Bible's pattern for how a person is counted righteous.

**Genesis 12:1 —** *Now the LORD had said unto Abram, Get thee out of thy country, and from thy kindred, and from thy father's house, unto a land that I will shew thee:*

**Genesis 15:6 —** *And he believed in the LORD; and he counted it to him for righteousness.*

### The Abrahamic Promises

| Promise | Content | Main passages |
|---|---|---|
| Land | A literal land is promised to Abraham's seed | Genesis 12:1, 7; 13:14–17; 15:18–21 |
| Seed | Abraham will become a great nation and father of many nations | Genesis 12:2; 15:1–6; 17:1–8 |
| Blessing | God will bless Abraham and bless all families through his seed | Genesis 12:2–3; 22:15–18; Galatians 3:16 |

**KEY —** Abraham was promised both a physical and a spiritual seed. God promised that his descendants would be both numerable and innumerable, describing his seed as the sand of the sea (Gen. 13:16; 22:17; 32:12) and also as the stars of heaven (Gen. 15:5; 22:17). The New Testament subsequently distinguishes Abraham's physical descendants, "the children of the flesh," from "the children of the promise" (Rom. 9:6–8). Those who possess Abraham's faith are described as his children spiritually: "they which are of faith, the same are the children of Abraham" (Gal. 3:7; cf. Rom. 4:11, 16; Gal. 3:29).

## Check Your Understanding

1. What did mankind seek at Babel?
2. How did God judge Babel and why?
3. What did God command Abram to leave?
4. State the land, seed, and blessing promises.
5. How does the New Testament connect Abraham's promised Seed with Christ?

UNIT 2 — THE FAMILY THAT BECOMES ISRAEL

# Lesson 5 — Isaac and Jacob: The Promise Continues and Israel Is Named

**Lesson Overview:** The covenant line continues through Isaac, the promised son of Abraham and Sarah, and then through Jacob. God changes Jacob's name to Israel, and Jacob's twelve sons become the tribal fathers of the nation.

**MAIN PASSAGES:** Genesis 17:15–21; Genesis 21–22; Genesis 25–35; Genesis 48–49; Numbers 1:5–16

**KEY VERSE | Genesis 32:28 —** *Thy name shall be called no more Jacob, but Israel: for as a prince hast thou power with God and with men, and hast prevailed.*

**READ:** Genesis 17:15–21; 21:1–12; 22:1–18; 25:19–34; 27–28; 32:22–32; 35:9–29; 48–49; 1 Chronicles 2:1–2.

## The Story in Scripture

| Story movement | Scripture |
|---|---|
| Isaac is born | Genesis 21:1–7 — God fulfills His promise to Abraham and Sarah. |
| Isaac is offered | Genesis 22:1–18 — God provides a ram and confirms the promise. |
| Jacob receives the birthright and blessing | Genesis 25:29–34; 27:1–40. |
| God meets Jacob at Bethel | Genesis 28:10–22 — the Abrahamic promises are repeated. |

| Story movement | Scripture |
|---|---|
| Jacob becomes Israel | Genesis 32:22–32; 35:9–12. |
| Israel's twelve sons are named | Genesis 35:22–26; 49:1–28. |

## 1. Isaac: The Promised Son

Isaac, the promised son of Abraham and **Sarah**, is born when his parents are old. His birth proves that the promise depends upon God's power and that God always keeps His word. At Moriah, God tests Abraham, Isaac is bound on the altar, and God provides a **ram** in his place.

- Remember, God promised Abraham a seed (Lesson 4). Abraham and Sarah waited about twenty-five years for that son.
- Abraham also had a son named Ishmael by Hagar, but God said the covenant would continue through Isaac (Genesis 17:19–21).
- Moriah is a picture of the cross: a father offering his son, and God providing a substitute.

> **Genesis 21:1–2 —** *And the LORD visited Sarah as he had said, and the LORD did unto Sarah as he had spoken. For Sarah conceived, and bare Abraham a son in his old age, at the set time of which God had spoken to him.*
>
> **Genesis 22:8 —** *...My son, God will provide himself a lamb for a burnt offering...*

## 2. Jacob Becomes Israel

Isaac's son Jacob often relies on scheming and deception, but God disciplines and preserves him. At **Bethel** God repeats the Abrahamic promises to Jacob. At Peniel Jacob wrestles with God, is broken and blessed, and God changes his name to **Israel**.

- Isaac had twin sons, Esau and Jacob. Esau despised his birthright, and God chose Jacob to carry the promise (Genesis 25:23, 34).
- Jacob deceived his father to get the blessing and had to run from Esau. That is why he is alone when God meets him at Bethel.
- The new name "Israel" becomes the name of the whole nation that comes from him.

> **Genesis 28:13** — *And, behold, the LORD stood above it, and said, I am the LORD God of Abraham thy father, and the God of Isaac: the land whereon thou liest, to thee will I give it, and to thy seed;*

### From Abraham to Israel's Tribes

| Generation | Key people | Place in the story | Passages |
|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | Abraham and Sarah | Receive the covenant promises | Genesis 12; 15; 17 |
| 2 | Isaac and Rebekah | The promise continues through Isaac | Genesis 21–27 |
| 3 | Jacob / Israel | Receives the promise and becomes father of twelve sons | Genesis 28; 32; 35 |
| 4 | Twelve sons | Become the tribal fathers of Israel | Genesis 35:22–26; 49 |

## 3. The Twelve Sons

Jacob's twelve sons become the tribal fathers of the nation of Israel. Levi is set apart for priestly service. Joseph receives a double portion through his sons Ephraim and Manasseh. The royal promise that leads to David and to Jesus Christ comes through the tribe of **Judah**.

- Abram had children with more than one woman, and so did Jacob. This is not proof that God is okay with it; He clearly is not (Genesis 2:24). It shows that God will take our mistakes and still make something beautiful out of our lives.
- Watch the tribe of Judah. The sceptre (the right to rule as king) will stay with Judah until Shiloh, the Messiah, comes.
- In the next lesson, one of these sons, Joseph, is sold into Egypt, and God uses it to save the whole family.

**Genesis 49:10 —** *The sceptre shall not depart from Judah, nor a lawgiver from between his feet, until Shiloh come; and unto him shall the gathering of the people be.*

### Jacob's Sons and Important Tribal Connections

| Mother | Sons | Important connection |
|---|---|---|
| Leah | Reuben, Simeon, Levi, Judah, Issachar, Zebulun | Priesthood through Levi; royal line through Judah |
| Rachel | Joseph, Benjamin | Joseph represented by Ephraim and Manasseh |
| Bilhah | Dan, Naphtali | Tribal fathers in Israel |
| Zilpah | Gad, Asher | Tribal fathers in Israel |

## Check Your Understanding

1. Why was Isaac's birth important to the covenant story?
2. What did God provide at Moriah?
3. Where did God repeat the Abrahamic promises to Jacob?
4. Why did God rename Jacob Israel?
5. How do Levi, Joseph, and Judah have special tribal roles?

UNIT 2 — THE FAMILY THAT BECOMES ISRAEL

# Lesson 6 — Joseph: God Sends a Preserver to Egypt

**Lesson Overview:** Joseph, one of the 12 sons of Jacob, is hated, sold, falsely accused, and imprisoned, but the LORD remains with him. God raises him beside Pharaoh and uses him to preserve Jacob's family, moving Israel into Egypt for the next stage of the story.

**MAIN PASSAGES:** Genesis 37–50; Psalm 105:16–24; Acts 7:9–16; Hebrews 11:22

**KEY VERSE | Genesis 50:20 —** *But as for you, ye thought evil against me; but God meant it unto good…to save much people alive.*

**READ:** Genesis 37; 39–50; Psalm 105:16–24; Acts 7:9–16; Hebrews 11:22.

## The Story in Scripture

| Story movement | Scripture |
|---|---|
| Joseph dreams | Genesis 37:1–11 — his brothers and parents will bow before him. |
| Joseph is sold | Genesis 37:18–36 — he is taken into Egypt. |
| Joseph serves and suffers | Genesis 39–40 — the LORD is with him in Potiphar's house and prison. |
| Joseph interprets Pharaoh's dreams | Genesis 41 — he is raised to authority. |
| Joseph's brothers come for food | Genesis 42–45 — Joseph tests and reveals himself to them. |

| Story movement | Scripture |
| --- | --- |
| Jacob's family moves to Egypt | Genesis 46–47. |
| Joseph explains God's providence | Genesis 50:15–21. |

## 1. From Favorite Son to Prisoner

Jacob favors Joseph and gives him a coat of many colours. Joseph's dreams of ruling over his family make his brothers hate him even more, and they sell him into **Egypt**. In Potiphar's house and in prison, Joseph refuses to sin because it would be sin against **God**.

- Remember, Jacob (Israel) had twelve sons (Lesson 5). Joseph was the son of Rachel and his father's favorite.
- The brothers first planned to kill him, but Judah suggested selling him to traders instead (Genesis 37:26–27).
- Even as a slave and a prisoner, "the LORD was with Joseph" (Genesis 39:2, 21).

**Genesis 37:28 —** *...they drew and lifted up Joseph out of the pit, and sold Joseph to the Ishmeelites for twenty pieces of silver: and they brought Joseph into Egypt.*

**Genesis 39:9 —** *...how then can I do this great wickedness, and sin against God?*

## 2. From Prisoner to Preserver

God gives Joseph understanding of dreams. Pharaoh sets Joseph over all the land of Egypt, and Joseph stores up food during seven years of plenty before seven years of **famine**. The famine brings his brothers to Egypt, and Jacob's whole household of **seventy** souls moves there. What his brothers meant for evil, God meant for **good**.

- Joseph's brothers bow down before him, just as his dreams had said (Genesis 42:6).

- Joseph forgives his brothers because he sees God's hand in everything that happened (Genesis 45:5–8).
- This is how Israel ends up in Egypt. It is good at first, but in the next lesson a new Pharaoh makes them slaves, just as God had told Abraham (Genesis 15:13).

**Genesis 41:41** — *And Pharaoh said unto Joseph, See, I have set thee over all the land of Egypt.*

**Genesis 45:7** — *And God sent me before you to preserve you a posterity in the earth, and to save your lives by a great deliverance.*

### Joseph's Reversals

| Low point | God's providence | Result | Passages |
|---|---|---|---|
| Rejected by brothers | Taken to Egypt | Placed in Potiphar's house | Genesis 37; 39:1–6 |
| Falsely accused | The LORD is with him in prison | Trusted by the keeper | Genesis 39:7–23 |
| Forgotten by the butler | Pharaoh dreams at God's appointed time | Joseph is summoned | Genesis 40–41 |
| Family famine | Joseph has stored food | Israel's household is preserved | Genesis 42–47 |

## Check Your Understanding

1. Why did Joseph's brothers hate him?
2. How did Joseph respond to temptation?
3. Why did Jacob's family move to Egypt?

UNIT 3 — ISRAEL IS CALLED OUT AND ESTABLISHED

# Lesson 7 — Moses and Pharaoh: Passover and the Exodus

**Lesson Overview:** Egypt enslaves Israel, but God remembers His covenant, calls Moses, judges Egypt, shelters Israel through the Passover blood, and brings the nation through the Red Sea.

**MAIN PASSAGES:** Exodus 1–15; Psalm 105:23–45; 1 Corinthians 5:7; Hebrews 11:23–29

**KEY VERSE | Exodus 12:13 —** *And the blood shall be to you for a token upon the houses where ye are: and when I see the blood, I will pass over you…*

**READ:** Exodus 1–6; 7–11; 12:1–51; 13:17–15:21; Psalm 105:23–45; 1 Corinthians 5:7; Hebrews 11:23–29.

## The Story in Scripture

| Story movement | Scripture |
|---|---|
| Israel is enslaved | Exodus 1:8–22. |
| Moses is preserved | Exodus 2:1–10; Hebrews 11:23. |
| God calls Moses | Exodus 3:1–4:17. |
| The plagues strike Egypt | Exodus 7–11; 12:12. |
| The Passover lamb is slain | Exodus 12:1–36. |
| Israel leaves Egypt | Exodus 12:37–51. |

| Story movement | Scripture |
| --- | --- |
| God opens the Red Sea | Exodus 14–15. |

## 1. Moses Is Called

A new Pharaoh enslaves Israel and orders the Hebrew baby boys killed. God preserves baby Moses, who grows up in Pharaoh's own house and later spends forty years in Midian. Then God calls him from the burning **bush**. God has seen Israel's affliction and remembered His covenant, and He reveals His name: I AM THAT **I AM**.

- Remember, all of Jacob's sons (Israel, the 12 tribes) came to Egypt for help. They stayed there, and a few hundred years later their descendants were enslaved because Pharaoh feared they would take over.
- God had told Abraham this would happen, and that He would bring them out again (Genesis 15:13–14).
- Satan tries again to destroy the line of promise by killing the Hebrew sons, but God preserves the deliverer.

**Exodus 2:24** — *And God heard their groaning, and God remembered his covenant with Abraham, with Isaac, and with Jacob.*

**Exodus 3:14** — *And God said unto Moses, I AM THAT I AM…*

## 2. Pharaoh, the Plagues, and Passover

Pharaoh hardens his heart again and again. The plagues show the LORD's power and judge the gods of Egypt. Before the final plague, each household must kill a lamb without **blemish** and put its blood on the door posts. God promises, "when I see the **blood**, I will pass over you."

- Each plague showed that Egypt's gods were powerless before the LORD (Exodus 12:12).

- The last plague was the death of the firstborn. Only the blood of the lamb kept death out of a house.
- Israel was to keep the Passover every year so they would never forget how God redeemed them (Exodus 12:14).

**Exodus 12:5 —** *Your lamb shall be without blemish, a male of the first year…*

**1 Corinthians 5:7 —** *…For even Christ our passover is sacrificed for us:*

### Passover Instructions

| Element | Instruction | Meaning in the story | Scripture |
|---|---|---|---|
| Lamb | Male of the first year, without blemish | A spotless substitute is selected | Exodus 12:3–5 |
| Blood | Placed on two side posts and upper door post | Marks the house under God's promise | Exodus 12:7, 13 |
| Meal | Roasted lamb, unleavened bread, bitter herbs | Israel eats ready to depart | Exodus 12:8–11 |
| Memorial | Kept as a feast in Israel | The deliverance is remembered | Exodus 12:14–28 |
| Christ | Called our Passover | The New Testament identifies the greater sacrifice | 1 Corinthians 5:7; 1 Peter 1:18–19 |

## 3. Through the Sea

Pharaoh changes his mind and chases Israel to the Red Sea. God opens the sea, Israel crosses on **dry** ground, and the waters return and destroy Egypt's army. The Exodus calls Israel out of bondage in Egypt to serve the LORD.

- Israel was trapped, with the sea in front and Pharaoh's army behind. Moses told them, “Stand still, and see the salvation of the LORD” (Exodus 14:13).
- On the other side, Moses and Israel sing a song of praise for their deliverance (Exodus 15:1).
- From here Israel travels toward Mount Sinai, where God will give the Law (next lesson).

**Exodus 14:22 —** *And the children of Israel went into the midst of the sea upon the dry ground: and the waters were a wall unto them on their right hand, and on their left.*

**KEY —** This pictures our salvation: FIRST, they are saved by the blood of a lamb. This blood rescues them from death and delivers them from bondage in the world (Egypt). THEN, they are “baptized” in the Red Sea as the next step of obedience. It was not their salvation, but the next step.

**KEY VERSE | 1 Cor. 10:1-2 —** *Moreover, brethren, I would not that ye should be ignorant, how that all our fathers were under the cloud, and all passed through the sea; And were all baptized unto Moses in the cloud and in the sea;*

## Check Your Understanding

1. Why did God send Moses to Pharaoh?
2. What did the plagues reveal about the LORD?
3. What were the instructions for the Passover lamb and blood?
4. How does the New Testament connect Passover with Christ?
5. What did crossing the Red Sea picture?

UNIT 3 — ISRAEL IS CALLED OUT AND ESTABLISHED

# Lesson 8 — Moses in the Wilderness: Sinai, the Tabernacle, and Kadesh

**Lesson Overview:** God brings Israel to Sinai, gives the Law, establishes the priesthood and sacrifices, and places the tabernacle at the center. Israel's unbelief at Kadesh brings forty years of wandering before Joshua leads the next generation.

**MAIN PASSAGES:** Exodus 19–40; Leviticus 1–17; Numbers 13–21; Deuteronomy 6–8; Hebrews 9–10

**KEY VERSE | Exodus 25:8 —** *And let them make me a sanctuary; that I may dwell among them.*

**READ:** Exodus 19–24; 25–31; 32–34; 40; Leviticus 1–7; 16–17; Numbers 13–14; 21:4–9; Deuteronomy 6–8; 31; 34; Hebrews 9–10.

## The Story in Scripture

| Story movement | Scripture |
|---|---|
| Israel arrives at Sinai | Exodus 19 — God calls the nation a peculiar treasure, kingdom of priests, and holy nation. |
| God gives the commandments | Exodus 20–24. |
| God gives the tabernacle pattern | Exodus 25–31. |
| Israel worships the golden calf | Exodus 32–34. |

| Story movement | Scripture |
| --- | --- |
| The glory fills the tabernacle | Exodus 40:33–38. |
| Israel refuses the land | Numbers 13–14. |
| God provides the brazen serpent | Numbers 21:4–9; John 3:14–15. |

## 1. Sinai: A Redeemed Nation Receives the Law

In the third month after leaving Egypt, Israel arrives at Mount Sinai. God redeemed Israel before He gave them the **Law**. The Law orders Israel's national life, worship, sacrifices, calendar, and justice. It also exposes **sin** and teaches that only God is perfectly holy.

- Remember, God brought Israel out of Egypt by the blood of the lamb and through the Red Sea (Lesson 7). Now He forms them into a nation.
- God calls Israel a peculiar treasure, a kingdom of priests, and an holy nation (Exodus 19:5–6).
- While Moses is on the mountain, the people make a golden calf. That shows how quickly the heart turns from God (Exodus 32).

**Exodus 20:2–3 —** *I am the LORD thy God, which have brought thee out of the land of Egypt, out of the house of bondage. Thou shalt have no other gods before me.*

**Romans 3:20 —** *...for by the law is the knowledge of sin.*

## 2. The Tabernacle: God Dwells Among Israel

God gives Moses the pattern for the tabernacle, a tent where He will dwell among His people. It stands at the center of Israel's **camp**. Its court, altar, laver, holy place, and most holy place show that Israel must approach God in the way He commands. When it is finished, the glory of the LORD fills it.

- The tabernacle could be taken down and carried, because Israel was still traveling toward the promised land.
- The ark and mercy seat sat in the most holy place, where the high priest went in only once a year with blood (Leviticus 16; Hebrews 9:7).
- The tabernacle points forward to Christ, our better sacrifice and High Priest.

**Exodus 40:34 —** *Then a cloud covered the tent of the congregation, and the glory of the LORD filled the tabernacle.*

**Hebrews 9:12 —** *Neither by the blood of goats and calves, but by his own blood he entered in once into the holy place, having obtained eternal redemption for us.*

### The Tabernacle and Its Furniture

| Area | Furniture | Function | Study |
|---|---|---|---|
| Court | Brazen altar | Sacrifice is offered | Exodus 27:1–8; Leviticus 1 |
| Court | Laver | Priests wash before service | Exodus 30:17–21 |
| Holy place | Candlestick | Light burns before the LORD | Exodus 25:31–40 |
| Holy place | Table of shewbread | Bread stands before the LORD | Exodus 25:23–30 |
| Holy place | Altar of incense | Incense rises before the veil | Exodus 30:1–10 |
| Most holy place | Ark and mercy seat | God meets with the high priest | Exodus 25:10–22; Leviticus 16 |

## 3. Kadesh: Unbelief Delays the Journey

At Kadesh, twelve spies are sent to search out the promised land. Ten spies fear the giants, but Joshua and **Caleb** trust the LORD. The nation refuses to go in, and God sentences them to wander **forty** years in the wilderness because of **unbelief**.

- Remember, this is the land God promised to Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob (Lessons 4–5). Israel was standing at its border!
- Every adult twenty years old and upward who refused would die in the wilderness, except Joshua and Caleb (Numbers 14:29–30).
- God still provided manna, water, and even healing through the brazen serpent (Numbers 21:8–9; John 3:14–15).
- Moses dies on Mount Nebo, and Joshua leads the new generation. That is where Lesson 9 begins (Deuteronomy 34).

**Numbers 13:30 —** *And Caleb stilled the people before Moses, and said, Let us go up at once, and possess it; for we are well able to overcome it.*

**Hebrews 3:19 —** *So we see that they could not enter in because of unbelief.*

### The Kadesh Decision

| Response | Spokesmen | Message | Result |
|---|---|---|---|
| Unbelief | Ten spies | The people are stronger; we cannot go up | Israel fears and rebels |
| Faith | Joshua and Caleb | The LORD is with us; fear them not | They are preserved to enter the land |
| Judgment | The LORD | The unbelieving generation will not enter | Forty years of wandering |

## Check Your Understanding

1. What did the Law regulate in Israel's national life?
2. How did the tabernacle teach God's holiness and presence?
3. Why did Israel refuse the land at Kadesh?

UNIT 3 — ISRAEL IS CALLED OUT AND ESTABLISHED

# Lesson 9 — Joshua and Rahab: Israel Enters the Promised Land

**Lesson Overview:** Joshua succeeds Moses and leads Israel across Jordan. Rahab believes the LORD and is preserved at Jericho. God gives the victories, the land is divided among the tribes, and Israel renews the covenant.

**MAIN PASSAGES:** Joshua 1–24; Hebrews 11:30–31; James 2:25; Psalm 78:52–55

**KEY VERSE | Joshua 1:9 —** *Have not I commanded thee? Be strong and of a good courage…for the LORD thy God is with thee whithersoever thou goest.*

**READ:** Joshua 1–8; 10–12; 13–21; 23–24; Hebrews 11:30–31; James 2:25.

## The Story in Scripture

| Story movement | Scripture |
|---|---|
| Joshua is commissioned | Joshua 1:1–9. |
| Rahab receives the spies | Joshua 2; Hebrews 11:31. |
| Israel crosses Jordan | Joshua 3–4. |
| Jericho falls | Joshua 5:13–6:27; Hebrews 11:30. |
| Achan's sin is judged | Joshua 7. |
| The land is conquered and divided | Joshua 10–21. |

| Story movement | Scripture |
| --- | --- |
| Joshua renews the covenant | Joshua 23–24. |

## 1. Joshua Leads by God's Word

Joshua's courage is tied to obedience. He is to meditate in the book of the **law** and do what it says. God brings Israel across Jordan and commands memorial **stones** so later generations will know what He did.

- Remember, God promised to Abram and to his sons a LAND and NATION that would go on forever.
- When Israel is led out of Egypt, it is finally time to go to possess this land.
- Moses has died, and Joshua, one of the two faithful spies, now leads the new generation (Joshua 1:1–2).
- There were giants and major cities (Jericho) in that land that they had to overcome to get the promised land as God promised and commanded.

> **Joshua 1:8 —** *This book of the law shall not depart out of thy mouth; but thou shalt meditate therein day and night, that thou mayest observe to do according to all that is written therein: for then thou shalt make thy way prosperous, and then thou shalt have good success.*

> **Joshua 3:17 —** *And the priests that bare the ark of the covenant of the LORD stood firm on dry ground in the midst of Jordan, and all the Israelites passed over on dry ground, until all the people were passed clean over Jordan.*

## 2. Rahab Believes the LORD

Rahab has heard what the LORD did in Egypt and believes that He is God in Heaven and earth. She hides the spies and places the scarlet line in her window. Her household is preserved when Jericho falls, and she later appears in the line of David and **Jesus**.

- Joshua sends two spies to look over Jericho, the first walled city in Israel's path (Joshua 2:1).
- Rahab is a Canaanite who lives on the wall of Jericho. The whole city is afraid because they heard how God dried up the Red Sea forty years earlier (Joshua 2:9–10).
- The spies promise to spare her family if the scarlet line is in her window, much like the blood on the door at Passover.

**Joshua 2:11 —** *...the LORD your God, he is God in heaven above, and in earth beneath.*

**Matthew 1:5 —** *And Salmon begat Booz of Rachab; and Booz begat Obed of Ruth; and Obed begat Jesse;*

## 3. Conquest, Inheritance, and Choice

Jericho falls by God's power. Achan's hidden **sin** brings defeat at Ai until it is judged. The major campaigns break Canaanite resistance, the tribes receive inheritances, and Joshua calls Israel to **choose** whom they will serve.

- Israel marched around Jericho once a day for six days and seven times on the seventh day, and then the walls fell (Joshua 6:15–20).
- Achan kept silver, gold, and a garment that God had said to destroy. One man's hidden sin affected the whole nation (Joshua 7:1, 21).
- The land promise to Abraham is now being fulfilled as each tribe receives its portion (Joshua 21:43).

**Hebrews 11:30 —** *By faith the walls of Jericho fell down, after they were compassed about seven days.*

**Joshua 24:15 —** *...choose you this day whom ye will serve... but as for me and my house, we will serve the LORD.*

### Joshua's Major Movements

| Movement | Story | Scripture |
|---|---|---|
| Entrance | Jordan crossing and memorial stones | Joshua 3–4 |
| Central campaign | Jericho, Achan, and Ai | Joshua 5–8 |
| Southern campaign | Gibeon and southern kings | Joshua 9–10 |
| Northern campaign | Northern coalition defeated | Joshua 11–12 |
| Inheritance | Land divided among the tribes | Joshua 13–21 |
| Renewal | Joshua's final charge and covenant renewal | Joshua 23–24 |

## Check Your Understanding

1. How were Joshua's courage and obedience connected?
2. What did Rahab believe about the LORD?
3. Why did Jericho fall?
4. What did Achan's story teach Israel?
5. How did Joshua complete Israel's entrance into the land?

UNIT 3 — ISRAEL IS CALLED OUT AND ESTABLISHED

# Lesson 10 — The Judges and Ruth: Collapse, Deliverance, and a Redeemer

**Lesson Overview:** After Joshua, Israel repeatedly forsakes the LORD, suffers oppression, cries for help, and receives deliverance through judges. During this unstable period, Ruth trusts Israel's God, Boaz redeems her family, and the line of David is preserved.

**MAIN PASSAGES:** Judges 1–21; Ruth 1–4; Hebrews 11:32–34; Matthew 1:5–6

**KEY VERSE | Ruth 1:16 —** *...thy people shall be my people, and thy God my God:*

**READ:** Judges 2:6–23; 3–8; 10–16; 17:6; 21:25; Ruth 1–4; Hebrews 11:32–34; Matthew 1:5–6.

## The Story in Scripture

| Story movement | Scripture |
|---|---|
| Israel forsakes the LORD | Judges 2:6–15. |
| God raises judges | Judges 2:16–19. |
| Deborah and Barak deliver Israel | Judges 4–5. |
| Gideon defeats Midian | Judges 6–8. |
| Samson fights the Philistines | Judges 13–16. |

| Story movement | Scripture |
|---|---|
| Ruth follows Naomi to Bethlehem | Ruth 1. |
| Boaz redeems Ruth | Ruth 2–4. |

## 1. The Cycle of the Judges

After Joshua and his generation die, Israel fails to drive out the Canaanites and their idols. Each new generation turns from the LORD, and the same cycle repeats: sin, oppression, crying out, and deliverance. God raises up judges to **deliver** Israel. The problem is summed up in the words, "every man did that which was right in his own **eyes**."

- Remember, God gave Israel the land under Joshua (Lesson 9), but they did not finish removing the idol-worshipping nations as God commanded (Judges 1:27–28; 2:2).
- A new generation grew up that did not know the LORD or the works He had done.
- Judges like Deborah, Gideon, and Samson delivered Israel for a time, but the nation kept sliding downward.

**Judges 2:10 —** *...there arose another generation after them, which knew not the LORD, nor yet the works which he had done for Israel.*

**Judges 2:16 —** *Nevertheless the LORD raised up judges, which delivered them out of the hand of those that spoiled them.*

### The Judges Cycle

| Step | What happens | Key passages |
|---|---|---|
| Sin | Israel serves other gods | Judges 2:11–13 |
| Oppression | God gives Israel into enemy hands | Judges 2:14–15 |

| Step | What happens | Key passages |
|---|---|---|
| Crying | The people groan under bondage | Judges 2:18; 3:9, 15 |
| Deliverer | The LORD raises a judge | Judges 2:16, 18 |
| Rest | The land rests while the judge lives | Judges 3:11, 30; 5:31 |
| Return | The people become corrupt again | Judges 2:19 |

## 2. Ruth and Boaz

During the days of the judges, a famine sends Naomi's family to Moab, where her husband and sons die. Ruth, her Moabite daughter-in-law, chooses Naomi's people and Naomi's God. In Bethlehem she gleans in the field of **Boaz**, a near kinsman. Boaz acts as kinsman-**redeemer**, buys back the family inheritance, and marries Ruth. Their son Obed becomes the grandfather of King **David**.

- Ruth takes place "in the days when the judges ruled" (Ruth 1:1), a bright spot in a dark time.
- Ruth was a Gentile, yet God brought her into Israel and into the line of the promised Seed (Matthew 1:5).
- In the darkest period of Judges, God quietly preserves the royal line that leads to David and to Jesus Christ.

> **Ruth 2:1** — *And Naomi had a kinsman of her husband's, a mighty man of wealth, of the family of Elimelech; and his name was Boaz.*
>
> **Ruth 4:17** — *...and they called his name Obed: he is the father of Jesse, the father of David.*

### Ruth's Place in the Story

| Character | Action | Importance | Passages |
|---|---|---|---|
| Naomi | Returns to Bethlehem in bitterness | The family and inheritance need restoration | Ruth 1 |
| Ruth | Trusts Israel's God and serves faithfully | A Gentile believer enters Israel and David's line | Ruth 1–2; Matthew 1:5 |
| Boaz | Acts as kinsman-redeemer | Redeems the inheritance and takes Ruth as wife | Ruth 2–4 |
| Obed | Son of Boaz and Ruth | Grandfather of David | Ruth 4:13–22 |

## Check Your Understanding

1. What caused the repeated cycle in Judges?
2. Name several judges and the enemies they faced.
3. What did Ruth choose in Ruth 1:16?
4. What did Boaz do as kinsman-redeemer?
5. How does Ruth connect Judges with David and Christ?

UNIT 4 — ISRAEL'S KINGS AND PROPHETS

# Lesson 11 — Samuel and Saul: From Judges to Kings

**Lesson Overview:** Samuel hears God's voice and leads Israel at the end of the judges. The nation demands a king like the surrounding nations. Saul begins with promise but repeatedly disobeys, and God rejects his dynasty.

**MAIN PASSAGES:** 1 Samuel 1–15; 1 Samuel 28–31; Acts 13:20–22

**KEY VERSE | 1 Samuel 15:22 —** *Behold, to obey is better than sacrifice, and to hearken than the fat of rams.*

**READ:** 1 Samuel 1–3; 7–10; 12–15; 28–31; Acts 13:20–22.

## The Story in Scripture

| Story movement | Scripture |
|---|---|
| Hannah prays for a son | 1 Samuel 1. |
| Samuel hears the LORD | 1 Samuel 3. |
| Samuel judges Israel | 1 Samuel 7. |
| Israel demands a king | 1 Samuel 8. |
| Saul is chosen and anointed | 1 Samuel 9–10. |
| Saul acts presumptuously | 1 Samuel 13. |

| Story movement | Scripture |
|---|---|
| Saul spares Agag | 1 Samuel 15. |
| Saul dies on Gilboa | 1 Samuel 28–31. |

## 1. Samuel: A Prophet Who Hears God

Hannah prays for a son and gives Samuel to the LORD. As a boy serving at the tabernacle, he hears God's call and answers, "Speak; for thy servant **heareth**." Samuel grows to be both a prophet and the last **judge** of Israel, and he leads the nation back from idolatry.

- Remember, the time of the judges was dark: "every man did that which was right in his own eyes" (Lesson 10). Even the priest Eli's sons were wicked (1 Samuel 2:12).
- "The word of the LORD was precious in those days" (1 Samuel 3:1). God was not speaking often.
- Samuel will anoint Israel's first two kings, Saul and David.

> **1 Samuel 3:10** — *And the LORD came, and stood, and called as at other times, Samuel, Samuel. Then Samuel answered, Speak; for thy servant heareth.*
>
> **1 Samuel 3:19** — *And Samuel grew, and the LORD was with him, and did let none of his words fall to the ground.*

## 2. Saul: A King Who Will Not Obey

Israel demands a king to judge them like all the **nations**. The request shows they are rejecting the LORD's rule. Saul looks impressive, but he will not fully obey God's Word. He offers a sacrifice he had no right to offer, and later spares King Agag and the best of the spoil. Samuel tells him that to **obey** is better than sacrifice, and God seeks a man after His own **heart**.

- Remember, God promised that kings would come from Judah (Genesis 49:10). Saul was from the tribe of Benjamin.

- God planned for Israel to have a king (Deuteronomy 17:14–15), but they wanted one like the other nations instead of waiting for God's choice.
- Because Saul would not obey, God chose David to be the next king (next lesson).

**1 Samuel 8:7 —** *...for they have not rejected thee, but they have rejected me, that I should not reign over them.*

**1 Samuel 13:14 —** *But now thy kingdom shall not continue: the LORD hath sought him a man after his own heart...*

### Saul's Rise and Rejection

| Stage | Event | What it reveals | Scripture |
|---|---|---|---|
| Chosen | Saul is publicly presented | Outward strength and public approval | 1 Samuel 9–10 |
| Presumptuous | Offers sacrifice instead of waiting | Will not remain under God's command | 1 Samuel 13:8–14 |
| Partly obedient | Spares Agag and the best spoil | Calls disobedience obedience | 1 Samuel 15:1–23 |
| Rejected | Kingdom will not continue in his line | God seeks a man after His own heart | 1 Samuel 13:14; 15:26–29 |
| Ruined | Consults the witch at Endor and dies | A tragic end to continued rebellion | 1 Samuel 28–31 |

## Check Your Understanding

1. How did Samuel enter the LORD's service?
2. Why was Israel's demand for a king spiritually serious?
3. What happened at Gilgal in 1 Samuel 13?
4. What did Saul do with Agag and the spoil?
5. Why did God reject Saul's dynasty?

UNIT 4 — ISRAEL'S KINGS AND PROPHETS

# Lesson 12 — David: Shepherd, Warrior, King, and Covenant Man

**Lesson Overview:** God chooses David from Judah, tests him through Goliath and Saul, and establishes him as king in Jerusalem. David sins seriously and faces consequences, yet he repents. God promises him an enduring house, throne, and kingdom fulfilled in Jesus Christ.

**MAIN PASSAGES:** 1 Samuel 16–31; 2 Samuel 1–24; 1 Chronicles 10–29; Psalm 51; Psalm 89; Luke 1:30–33

**KEY VERSE | 2 Samuel 7:16 —** *And thine house and thy kingdom shall be established for ever before thee: thy throne shall be established for ever.*

**READ:** 1 Samuel 16–17; 18–24; 30–31; 2 Samuel 2; 5–7; 11–12; 15–19; 22–24; Psalm 51; 89:19–37; Luke 1:30–33.

## The Story in Scripture

| Story movement | Scripture |
|---|---|
| David is anointed | 1 Samuel 16. |
| David defeats Goliath | 1 Samuel 17. |
| David flees Saul | 1 Samuel 18–24. |
| David becomes king | 2 Samuel 2; 5. |
| God makes the Davidic covenant | 2 Samuel 7. |

| Story movement | Scripture |
| --- | --- |
| David sins and repents | 2 Samuel 11–12; Psalm 51. |
| Absalom rebels | 2 Samuel 15–19. |
| David prepares for the temple | 1 Chronicles 22–29. |

## 1. David Is Chosen and Tested

God sends Samuel to Bethlehem to anoint one of Jesse's sons. God looks on the **heart** rather than the outward appearance, and He chooses David, the youngest, a shepherd. David faces Goliath in the name of the **LORD** and later refuses to take Saul's throne by force. Years of danger prepare the shepherd to rule the nation.

- Remember, Saul had been rejected as king (Lesson 11). David is from the tribe of Judah, the royal tribe promised in Genesis 49:10.
- David is the great-grandson of Ruth and Boaz (Lesson 10).
- Saul becomes jealous and tries to kill David, but David spares Saul's life twice because he is "the LORD's anointed" (1 Samuel 24:6; 26:9).

> **1 Samuel 16:7 —** *...for the LORD seeth not as man seeth; for man looketh on the outward appearance, but the LORD looketh on the heart.*
>
> **1 Samuel 17:45 —** *...Thou comest to me with a sword, and with a spear, and with a shield: but I come to thee in the name of the LORD of hosts, the God of the armies of Israel, whom thou hast defied.*

### David's Preparation

| Test | David's response | Lesson | Scripture |
|---|---|---|---|
| Anointing | Receives God's choice while still a shepherd | God sees the heart | 1 Samuel 16:1–13 |
| Goliath | Trusts the name of the LORD | Victory belongs to God | 1 Samuel 17 |
| Saul's hatred | Flees without taking revenge | Waits for God's time | 1 Samuel 18–24 |
| Ziklag | Encourages himself in the LORD | Seeks God in loss | 1 Samuel 30 |

## 2. David Rules and Receives the Covenant

After Saul dies, David becomes king, unites Israel, captures **Jerusalem** as the royal city, and brings the ark there. David wants to build a house (a temple) for God, but God says no. Instead, God promises to build David a house: an enduring dynasty, throne, and **kingdom** forever.

- This is the Davidic covenant (2 Samuel 7). It adds a KING to the promises of land, seed, and blessing given to Abraham.
- David's son Solomon will build the temple (next lesson).
- The angel Gabriel tells Mary that her Son will receive "the throne of his father David." Jesus is the King this promise points to.

**2 Samuel 5:7 —** *Nevertheless David took the strong hold of Zion: the same is the city of David.*

**Luke 1:32–33 —** *...the Lord God shall give unto him the throne of his father David: And he shall reign over the house of Jacob for ever...*

## 3. David Sins and Repents

David commits adultery with Bathsheba and arranges the death of her husband Uriah. The prophet Nathan confronts him with the words, "Thou art the **man**." David confesses and is forgiven, but he bears painful consequences in his household.

- Even the man after God's own heart was a sinner. The Bible does not hide the failures of its heroes.
- Psalm 51 is the prayer David wrote after Nathan confronted him.
- The consequences were real: the child died, and trouble came to David's family, including Absalom's rebellion (2 Samuel 12:10–14; 15–18).

**2 Samuel 12:13 —** *And David said unto Nathan, I have sinned against the LORD. And Nathan said unto David, The LORD also hath put away thy sin; thou shalt not die.*

**Psalm 51:10 —** *Create in me a clean heart, O God; and renew a right spirit within me.*

## Check Your Understanding

1. Why did God choose David?
2. What did David's years under Saul teach him?
3. What did God promise in the Davidic covenant?
4. How did Nathan confront David's sin?
5. How does Jesus fulfill the promise to David?

UNIT 4 — ISRAEL'S KINGS AND PROPHETS

# Lesson 13 — Solomon, Rehoboam, and Jeroboam: Temple Glory and a Divided Kingdom

**Lesson Overview:** Solomon receives wisdom, builds the temple, and rules at the height of the united kingdom. His compromised heart prepares judgment. Rehoboam's harsh answer and Jeroboam's false worship divide the nation into Israel and Judah.

**MAIN PASSAGES:** 1 Kings 1–12; 2 Chronicles 1–12; Deuteronomy 17:14–20; Ecclesiastes 12:13–14

**KEY VERSE | 1 Kings 12:20 —** *...there was none that followed the house of David, but the tribe of Judah only.*

**READ:** 1 Kings 1–3; 5–8; 10–12; 2 Chronicles 1–12; Deuteronomy 17:14–20; Ecclesiastes 12:13–14.

## The Story in Scripture

| Story movement | Scripture |
|---|---|
| Solomon asks for wisdom | 1 Kings 3. |
| Solomon builds the temple | 1 Kings 5–8. |
| The kingdom reaches glory | 1 Kings 10. |
| Solomon's heart turns | 1 Kings 11:1–13. |

| Story movement | Scripture |
|---|---|
| Rehoboam rejects wise counsel | 1 Kings 12:1–15. |
| The kingdom divides | 1 Kings 12:16–24. |
| Jeroboam creates false worship | 1 Kings 12:25–33. |

## 1. Solomon: Wisdom, Temple, and Compromise

David's son Solomon becomes king and asks God for an understanding heart to judge the people. He builds and dedicates the **temple** in Jerusalem, and Israel reaches great wealth and influence. Yet Solomon multiplies horses, riches, and wives against God's command in Deuteronomy 17, and his wives turn his **heart** after other gods.

- Remember, God promised David that his son would build God's house (2 Samuel 7:12–13). Solomon fulfills that promise.
- When the temple is dedicated, the glory of the LORD fills it, just as it filled the tabernacle (1 Kings 8:10–11).
- Solomon's reign is the high point of Israel's kingdom, but it does not last because his heart is divided.

> **1 Kings 3:9 —** *Give therefore thy servant an understanding heart to judge thy people, that I may discern between good and bad…*
>
> **1 Kings 11:4 —** *For it came to pass, when Solomon was old, that his wives turned away his heart after other gods: and his heart was not perfect with the LORD his God, as was the heart of David his father.*

### Solomon's Reign

| Stage | Strength or failure | Scripture |
|---|---|---|
| Wisdom | God gives wisdom to judge Israel | 1 Kings 3:5–28; 4:29–34 |
| Temple | The house of the LORD is built and dedicated | 1 Kings 5–8 |
| Glory | Israel reaches great wealth and international influence | 1 Kings 10 |
| Compromise | Horses, riches, and wives multiply | Deuteronomy 17:14–20; 1 Kings 10–11 |
| Judgment | God announces that the kingdom will be torn | 1 Kings 11:9–13, 26–40 |

## 2. Rehoboam and Jeroboam Divide the Nation

After Solomon dies, his son Rehoboam answers the people harshly, and ten tribes follow **Jeroboam**. The kingdom splits in two: the northern kingdom, called **Israel**, and the southern kingdom, called **Judah**, which keeps David's line and the temple. Jeroboam fears that worship in Jerusalem will pull the people back, so he sets up golden calves, false priests, and a substitute feast.

- God had warned Solomon that the kingdom would be torn from his son because of his idolatry, but for David's sake one tribe would remain (1 Kings 11:11–13).
- From here on, the Bible follows two kingdoms with two lines of kings. Keep the chart below handy!
- Even with the split, God keeps His promise to David. A son of David stays on the throne in Jerusalem.

> **1 Kings 12:28 —** *Whereupon the king took counsel, and made two calves of gold, and said unto them, It is too much for you to go up to Jerusalem: behold thy gods, O Israel, which brought thee up out of the land of Egypt.*

### The Split Kingdom

| Feature | Northern Kingdom — Israel | Southern Kingdom — Judah |
|---|---|---|
| First ruler | Jeroboam I | Rehoboam |
| Tribes | Ten northern tribes | Judah and Benjamin; faithful Levites also move south |
| Capital | First Shechem; later Samaria | Jerusalem |
| Worship | Golden calves at Bethel and Dan | Temple at Jerusalem |
| Ruling line | Several changing dynasties | Davidic dynasty |
| Final exile | Assyria takes Samaria | Babylon destroys Jerusalem |
| Main passages | 1 Kings 12–2 Kings 17 | 1 Kings 12–2 Kings 25; 2 Chronicles 10–36 |

## Check Your Understanding

1. What did Solomon ask God to give him?
2. What did the temple represent in Israel's story?
3. Which warnings in Deuteronomy 17 did Solomon violate?
4. Why did the kingdom divide after Solomon?
5. How did Jeroboam establish counterfeit worship?

UNIT 4 — ISRAEL'S KINGS AND PROPHETS

# Lesson 14 — Elijah, Elisha, the Kings, and the Prophets: Warning Before Exile

**Lesson Overview:** Israel and Judah continue under different kings while prophets call both kingdoms back to the LORD. Elijah and Elisha confront northern apostasy. Isaiah, Jeremiah, and other prophets warn Judah. Israel falls to Assyria, and Judah later falls to Babylon.

**MAIN PASSAGES:** 1 Kings 16–22; 2 Kings 1–25; 2 Chronicles 13–36; Isaiah; Jeremiah; Hosea; Amos

**KEY VERSE | 2 Kings 17:13 —** *Yet the LORD testified against Israel, and against Judah, by all the prophets, and by all the seers, saying, Turn ye from your evil ways…*

**READ:** 1 Kings 16:29–22:53; 2 Kings 1–10; 13–25; 2 Chronicles 26–36; Isaiah 1; 6; 36–39; Jeremiah 1; 7; 25; Hosea 4; Amos 5.

## The Story in Scripture

| Story movement | Scripture |
|---|---|
| Ahab and Jezebel establish Baal worship | 1 Kings 16:29–34. |
| Elijah confronts Israel at Carmel | 1 Kings 17–18. |
| Elisha continues the witness | 2 Kings 2–8. |

| Story movement | Scripture |
|---|---|
| Israel rejects the prophets | 2 Kings 17:7–23. |
| Assyria takes Samaria | 2 Kings 17:5–6. |
| Hezekiah trusts the LORD | 2 Kings 18–20; Isaiah 36–39. |
| Josiah responds to the Law | 2 Kings 22–23. |
| Babylon destroys Jerusalem | 2 Kings 24–25; 2 Chronicles 36. |

## 1. Elijah and Elisha Confront the Northern Kingdom

King Ahab and his wife Jezebel make Baal worship official in the northern kingdom. Elijah announces a drought, is fed by God, and challenges the prophets of **Baal** at Mount Carmel, where God answers by fire. Elisha succeeds **Elijah** and continues the prophetic witness through signs, warnings, and counsel.

- Remember, the kingdom split after Solomon (Lesson 13). The northern kingdom began with Jeroboam's golden calves, and every one of its kings continued in false worship.
- A prophet was God's messenger, sent to call the people and their kings back to God's Word.
- Elijah is taken up to heaven by a whirlwind, and Elisha asks for a double portion of his spirit (2 Kings 2:9–11).

> **1 Kings 18:21 —** *...How long halt ye between two opinions? if the LORD be God, follow him: but if Baal, then follow him...*

**1 Kings 18:39 —** *And when all the people saw it, they fell on their faces: and they said, The LORD, he is the God; the LORD, he is the God.*

## 2. The Kings and Prophets of Israel

Every northern king continues Jeroboam's false worship. Jonah, Amos, and Hosea preach during the later years of the northern kingdom. The nation refuses warning after warning, and **Assyria** captures the capital, Samaria, and carries Israel away.

- The northern kingdom lasted about 200 years and never had a godly king.
- God sent prophet after prophet before He judged them. He is patient, but His warnings are real.
- 2 Kings 17 gives God's own explanation of why Israel fell.

**2 Kings 17:6 —** *In the ninth year of Hoshea the king of Assyria took Samaria, and carried Israel away into Assyria…*

**2 Kings 17:14 —** *Notwithstanding they would not hear, but hardened their necks, like to the neck of their fathers, that did not believe in the LORD their God.*

### Northern Kingdom — Selected Kings and Prophets

| Period | Selected kings | Prophets and message | Outcome / study |
|---|---|---|---|
| First dynasty | Jeroboam I, Nadab | A man of God condemns the altar | Counterfeit worship begins (1 Kings 12–14) |
| Baasha to Omri | Baasha, Elah, Zimri, Omri | Jehu son of Hanani warns Baasha | Dynasties change through violence (1 Kings 15–16) |
| House of Omri | Ahab, Ahaziah, Joram | Elijah and Elisha confront Baal | Drought, Carmel, signs, judgment (1 Kings 17–2 Kings 9) |

| Period | Selected kings | Prophets and message | Outcome / study |
|---|---|---|---|
| House of Jehu | Jehu, Jehoahaz, Joash, Jeroboam II | Jonah, Amos, Hosea | Temporary strength; deep corruption (2 Kings 10–14) |
| Final years | Zechariah, Shallum, Menahem, Pekahiah, Pekah, Hoshea | Warnings continue, but Israel will not hear | Samaria falls to Assyria (2 Kings 15–17) |

## 3. Judah's Reforms and Final Fall

Judah keeps David's line but often follows idolatry too. When Assyria threatens Jerusalem, Hezekiah takes the enemy's letter to the LORD in **prayer**, and God destroys the Assyrian army. Josiah turns the nation back when the lost book of the Law is found. Isaiah, Micah, Jeremiah, Habakkuk, and Zephaniah warn Judah. At last **Babylon** destroys Jerusalem and the temple and carries the people captive.

- Judah lasted over 130 years longer than Israel, helped by godly kings like Hezekiah and Josiah.
- Jeremiah warned that the captivity would last seventy years (Jeremiah 25:11).
- Even in judgment, God keeps His promises. He preserves a remnant and David's royal line.

**2 Kings 19:19 —** *Now therefore, O LORD our God, I beseech thee, save thou us out of his hand, that all the kingdoms of the earth may know that thou art the LORD God, even thou only.*

**2 Chronicles 36:16 —** *But they mocked the messengers of God, and despised his words, and misused his prophets, until the wrath of the LORD arose against his people, till there was no remedy.*

### Southern Kingdom — Selected Kings and Prophets

| Period | Selected rulers | Prophets and message | Outcome / study |
|---|---|---|---|
| Early kingdom | Rehoboam, Abijah, Asa, Jehoshaphat | Shemaiah, Azariah, Hanani, Jehu | Compromise and reform (2 Chronicles 10–20) |
| Athaliah crisis | Jehoram, Ahaziah, Athaliah, Joash | Elijah's letter; Jehoiada and Zechariah | David's line preserved (2 Chronicles 21–24) |
| Assyrian era | Amaziah, Uzziah, Jotham, Ahaz, Hezekiah | Isaiah, Micah, Hosea | Jerusalem delivered from Assyria (2 Kings 18–20) |
| Final reform | Manasseh, Amon, Josiah | Nahum, Zephaniah, Jeremiah | Josiah responds to the Law (2 Kings 21–23) |
| Final kings | Jehoahaz, Jehoiakim, Jehoiachin, Zedekiah | Jeremiah, Habakkuk, Ezekiel | Jerusalem falls to Babylon (2 Kings 24–25) |

## Check Your Understanding

1. What did Elijah prove at Mount Carmel?
2. How did Elisha continue Elijah's ministry?
3. Why did Assyria conquer the northern kingdom?
4. What did Hezekiah and Josiah do differently from many kings?
5. Why did Babylon finally destroy Jerusalem?

UNIT 5 — EXILE, PRESERVATION, AND RETURN

# Lesson 15 — Daniel, Esther, Ezra, and Nehemiah: God Preserves His People

**Lesson Overview:** During Gentile rule, Daniel shows that the most High governs kingdoms, Esther's story displays providential preservation, and the return leaders rebuild the temple, teach the Law, and restore Jerusalem's walls while Israel awaits the promised King.

**MAIN PASSAGES:** Daniel 1–9; Esther 1–10; Ezra 1–10; Nehemiah 1–13; Haggai; Zechariah; Malachi

**KEY VERSE | Daniel 2:21 —** *And he changeth the times and the seasons: he removeth kings, and setteth up kings...*

**READ:** Daniel 1–7; 9; Esther 3–9; Ezra 1–7; Nehemiah 1–8; Haggai 1–2; Zechariah 9; 12–14; Malachi 3–4.

## The Story in Scripture

| Story movement | Scripture |
|---|---|
| Daniel purposes faithfulness | Daniel 1. |
| God reveals the course of kingdoms | Daniel 2; 7. |
| The three Hebrews refuse the image | Daniel 3. |

| Story movement | Scripture |
|---|---|
| Daniel survives the lions' den | Daniel 6. |
| Esther intercedes for her people | Esther 3–9. |
| Zerubbabel rebuilds the temple | Ezra 1–6; Haggai; Zechariah. |
| Ezra teaches the Law | Ezra 7–10. |
| Nehemiah rebuilds the wall | Nehemiah 1–8. |

## 1. Daniel and His Friends in Gentile Kingdoms

Daniel and his friends are taken to Babylon as young men. Daniel purposes in his **heart** not to defile himself with the king's food. God gives Daniel understanding of dreams and visions. The image in Daniel 2 and the beasts in Daniel 7 trace the Gentile empires until the kingdom is given to the Son of man. God preserves His servants in the fiery furnace and the lions' den, proving that the most High rules in the kingdom of **men**.

- Remember, Judah was carried captive to Babylon because they would not listen to the prophets (Lesson 14).
- Daniel was probably a teenager when he was taken. He stayed faithful far from home, family, and temple.
- For the first time, God's people are living under Gentile kings. Daniel shows that God is still in control of every kingdom.

**Daniel 1:8 —** *But Daniel purposed in his heart that he would not defile himself with the portion of the king's meat, nor with the wine which he drank…*

**Daniel 4:17 —** *...to the intent that the living may know that the most High ruleth in the kingdom of men, and giveth it to whomsoever he will...*

### Daniel's Kingdom Visions

| Empire | Daniel 2 image | Daniel 7 beast | Historical kingdom |
|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | Head of gold | Lion | Babylon |
| 2 | Breast and arms of silver | Bear | Medo-Persia |
| 3 | Belly and thighs of brass | Leopard | Greece |
| 4 | Legs of iron; feet of iron and clay | Dreadful beast with ten horns | Rome and its final form |
| Final | Stone becomes a great mountain | Son of man receives the kingdom | Christ's everlasting kingdom |

## 2. Esther and God's Providential Preservation

Persia conquers Babylon, and many Jews still live scattered across the empire. Haman plots to destroy them all. Mordecai tells Queen Esther she may have come to the kingdom "for such a **time** as this," and she goes to the king at the risk of her life. The plot is reversed, Haman is hanged on his own gallows, and the Jewish people are preserved.

- God's name is never mentioned in the book of Esther, yet His hand is seen all through it.
- If Haman's plan had worked, the line of the promised Seed would have been wiped out. This is another attack on God's promise.
- The Jews still celebrate this deliverance at the feast of Purim (Esther 9:26–28).

**Esther 4:14 —** *...who knoweth whether thou art come to the kingdom for such a time as this?*

**Esther 4:16 —** *...and so will I go in unto the king, which is not according to the law: and if I perish, I perish.*

## 3. The Return Leaders

After seventy years, Cyrus king of Persia allows the Jews to return home. Zerubbabel and Jeshua rebuild the **temple**. Ezra teaches the Law. Nehemiah rebuilds Jerusalem's **wall** and leads the people to renew the covenant. The restored nation is still under Gentile rule and still waits for the Messiah.

- Isaiah named Cyrus long before he was born (Isaiah 44:28; 45:1).
- Jeremiah's seventy years were fulfilled exactly as God said (Jeremiah 29:10; Ezra 1:1).
- Malachi is the last Old Testament prophet. After him, God is silent for about 400 years until John the Baptist (next lesson).

**Ezra 1:1 —** *Now in the first year of Cyrus king of Persia, that the word of the LORD by the mouth of Jeremiah might be fulfilled, the LORD stirred up the spirit of Cyrus king of Persia...*

**Nehemiah 6:15 —** *So the wall was finished in the twenty and fifth day of the month Elul, in fifty and two days.*

### The Main Returns to Jerusalem

| Leader | Persian ruler | Main work | Bible record |
|---|---|---|---|
| Zerubbabel and Jeshua | Cyrus | Return, altar, and rebuilt temple | Ezra 1–6; Haggai; Zechariah |
| Ezra | Artaxerxes | Teach the Law and correct disorder | Ezra 7–10 |

| Leader | Persian ruler | Main work | Bible record |
|---|---|---|---|
| Nehemiah | Artaxerxes | Rebuild the wall and renew covenant order | Nehemiah 1–13 |

## Check Your Understanding

1. What did Daniel decide before facing Babylon's tests?
2. How do Daniel 2 and 7 describe Gentile kingdoms?
3. How did Esther help preserve the Jewish people?
4. What work belongs to Zerubbabel, Ezra, and Nehemiah?
5. What promises still remained unfulfilled after the return?

UNIT 6 — JESUS CHRIST, THE PROMISED KING

# Lesson 16 — John the Baptist, Mary, Joseph, and Jesus: The King Comes to Israel

**Lesson Overview:** After centuries of prophetic expectation, John prepares the way, Jesus is born of a virgin in Bethlehem, and the eternal Word becomes flesh. His teaching, signs, and call of the disciples reveal Him as Israel's Messiah, Son of God, and promised King.

**MAIN PASSAGES:** Matthew 1–17; Mark 1–9; Luke 1–9; John 1–12; Isaiah 7:14; Micah 5:2

**KEY VERSE | Luke 2:11 —** *For unto you is born this day in the city of David a Saviour, which is Christ the Lord.*

**READ:** Matthew 1–4; 8–9; 13; 16–17; Mark 1–9; Luke 1–2; 4–9; John 1–12; Isaiah 7:14; 9:6–7; Micah 5:2.

## The Story in Scripture

| Story movement | Scripture |
|---|---|
| John's birth is announced | Luke 1:5–25, 57–80. |
| Jesus' birth is announced | Luke 1:26–38; Matthew 1:18–25. |
| Jesus is born in Bethlehem | Luke 2:1–20; Matthew 2:1–12. |
| John prepares Israel | Matthew 3:1–12; John 1:19–36. |

| Story movement | Scripture |
| --- | --- |
| Jesus is baptized and tempted | Matthew 3:13–4:11. |
| Jesus calls the disciples | Mark 1:14–20; 3:13–19. |
| Jesus teaches and performs signs | Matthew 5–13; John 2–11. |
| Peter confesses the Christ | Matthew 16:13–21. |

## 1. The Forerunner and the Birth of Christ

After about 400 years of silence, God sends the angel Gabriel to announce two births. John the Baptist will prepare the way of the **Lord**, just as Isaiah and Malachi foretold. Jesus is conceived by the Holy Ghost, born of the virgin Mary in the city of **Bethlehem**, and legally placed in David's house through Joseph.

- Remember, God promised the Seed of the woman (Genesis 3:15), the Seed of Abraham (Genesis 12:3), and a Son of David who would reign forever (2 Samuel 7). All of these promises meet in Jesus.
- Matthew 1 traces Jesus' legal right to David's throne through Joseph, His legal father.
- Wise men from the east come to worship Him as the one “born King of the Jews” (Matthew 2:2).

> **Isaiah 7:14 —** *Therefore the Lord himself shall give you a sign; Behold, a virgin shall conceive, and bear a son, and shall call his name Immanuel.*
>
> **Micah 5:2 —** *But thou, Bethlehem Ephratah, though thou be little among the thousands of Judah, yet out of thee shall he come forth unto me that is to be ruler in Israel…*

### Prophecy and the Birth Narratives

| Promise | Old Testament | Gospel fulfillment |
|---|---|---|
| Forerunner | Isaiah 40:3; Malachi 3:1 | Matthew 3:1–3; Mark 1:1–4 |
| Virgin-born Immanuel | Isaiah 7:14 | Matthew 1:18–25 |
| Born in Bethlehem | Micah 5:2 | Matthew 2:1–6; Luke 2:1–7 |
| Son of David | 2 Samuel 7:12–16; Isaiah 9:6–7 | Matthew 1:1; Luke 1:30–33 |
| Called out of Egypt | Hosea 11:1 | Matthew 2:13–15 |

## 2. The King and the Kingdom

John and Jesus both preach that the kingdom of **heaven** is at hand. This message concerns Israel's promised King and Heaven's visible rule on earth. Jesus also teaches the spiritual Kingdom of God, which Romans 14:17 describes as righteousness, peace, and joy in the Holy Ghost.

- Remember, the prophets promised a real King on David's throne ruling over Israel (Lesson 12). John and Jesus announced that this King had arrived.
- The kingdom was “at hand” because the King Himself was present.
- Before His ministry began, Jesus was baptized by John and then tempted by Satan in the wilderness. He won where Adam failed (Matthew 4:1–11).

> **Matthew 3:1–2 —** *In those days came John the Baptist, preaching in the wilderness of Judaea, And saying, Repent ye: for the kingdom of heaven is at hand.*
>
> **Romans 14:17 —** *For the kingdom of God is not meat and drink; but righteousness, and peace, and joy in the Holy Ghost.*

### Two Kingdom Expressions

| Expression | Main emphasis | Key passages |
|---|---|---|
| Kingdom of Heaven | Heaven's visible rule on earth through Israel's promised King | Matthew 3:1–2; 4:17; 5–7; 13; Luke 1:30–33 |
| Kingdom of God | God's spiritual rule; righteousness, peace, and joy in the Holy Ghost | Luke 17:20–21; John 3:3–5; Romans 14:17 |

## 3. Jesus and His Disciples

Jesus chooses twelve men whom He names **apostles**. He teaches with authority and performs signs: He heals sickness, commands nature, casts out devils, feeds multitudes, forgives sins, and raises the dead. When Peter confesses Him as the Christ, the Son of the living **God**, Jesus begins to teach the disciples that He must suffer, die, and rise again.

- The miracles were proof of who Jesus is. John wrote them down "that ye might believe that Jesus is the Christ, the Son of God" (John 20:31).
- As the religious leaders reject Him, Jesus speaks more and more about the cross (Matthew 16:21).
- These twelve will later carry the message to the world (next lesson).

> **Luke 6:13** — *And when it was day, he called unto him his disciples: and of them he chose twelve, whom also he named apostles;*
>
> **Matthew 16:16** — *And Simon Peter answered and said, Thou art the Christ, the Son of the living God.*

### The Twelve Apostles

| Group | Names | Key passages |
|---|---|---|
| First four | Simon Peter, Andrew, James, John | Matthew 10:2; Mark 1:16–20 |

| Group | Names | Key passages |
|---|---|---|
| Next four | Philip, Bartholomew, Thomas, Matthew | Matthew 10:3; John 1:43–51; 20:24–29 |
| Final four | James son of Alphaeus, Lebbaeus / Judas, Simon the Canaanite, Judas Iscariot | Matthew 10:3–4; Luke 6:15–16 |

## Check Your Understanding

1. How did John the Baptist prepare Israel?
2. How do the birth narratives connect Jesus with David and Bethlehem?
3. What is the main distinction between the Kingdom of Heaven and the Kingdom of God?
4. What did Jesus' miracles reveal about Him?
5. Why did Jesus begin teaching the disciples about the cross after Peter's confession?

UNIT 6 — JESUS CHRIST, THE PROMISED KING

# Lesson 17 — Jesus Christ and the Apostles: Rejection, Cross, Resurrection, and Commission

**Lesson Overview:** Israel's leaders reject their King, but Christ willingly fulfills God's redemptive purpose. He dies for sins, is buried, rises bodily on the third day, appears to witnesses, commissions the apostles, and ascends with the promise of His return.

**MAIN PASSAGES:** Psalm 22; Isaiah 52:13–53:12; Matthew 21–28; Luke 22–24; John 18–21; Acts 1:1–11; 1 Corinthians 15:1–28

**KEY VERSE | 1 Corinthians 15:3–4 —** *Christ died for our sins according to the scriptures; And...he was buried, and...he rose again the third day according to the scriptures:*

**READ:** Psalm 22; Isaiah 52:13–53:12; Zechariah 9:9; Matthew 21–28; Luke 22–24; John 18–21; Acts 1:1–11; 1 Corinthians 15:1–28.

## The Story in Scripture

| Story movement | Scripture |
|---|---|
| The King enters Jerusalem | Matthew 21:1–11; Zechariah 9:9. |
| Judas betrays Jesus | Matthew 26:14–16, 47–56. |
| Jesus is tried and condemned | Matthew 26:57–27:26; John 18–19. |
| Jesus is crucified | Matthew 27; John 19; Psalm 22; Isaiah 53. |

| Story movement | Scripture |
|---|---|
| Jesus is buried | Matthew 27:57–66. |
| Jesus rises bodily | Matthew 28; Luke 24; John 20–21. |
| Jesus commissions the apostles | Matthew 28:18–20; Luke 24:46–49; Acts 1:8. |
| Jesus ascends | Acts 1:9–11. |

## 1. The King Is Rejected

Jesus rides into Jerusalem on a donkey as Zechariah's promised **King**. The religious leaders plot His death, Judas betrays Him for thirty pieces of silver, and Pilate says, "I find no **fault** in him," yet gives in to the crowd. Christ willingly lays down His life.

- Remember, Satan has attacked the promised Seed since Genesis 3:15. Now he enters Judas to betray Jesus (Luke 22:3). But the cross will be Satan's defeat, not Christ's.
- The rejection involves specific leaders, Judas, Roman authority, and a pressured crowd. The Gospel must never be twisted into hatred of Jewish people.
- Jesus was not a victim: "No man taketh it from me, but I lay it down of myself" (John 10:18).

> **Zechariah 9:9 —** *...behold, thy King cometh unto thee: he is just, and having salvation; lowly, and riding upon an ass, and upon a colt the foal of an ass.*
>
> **John 19:4 —** *...Behold, I bring him forth to you, that ye may know that I find no fault in him.*

### From Jerusalem's Gate to the Cross

| Event | People involved | Scripture |
|---|---|---|
| Triumphal entry | Jesus, disciples, crowds | Matthew 21:1–11 |

| Event | People involved | Scripture |
|---|---|---|
| Final teaching | Jesus, disciples, religious leaders | Matthew 21–25; John 12–17 |
| Last Supper | Jesus and the Twelve | Luke 22:14–20; John 13–17 |
| Arrest | Judas, officers, disciples | Matthew 26:47–56; John 18:1–12 |
| Trials | Jewish council, Pilate, Herod | Matthew 26:57–27:26; Luke 23; John 18–19 |
| Crucifixion | Jesus between two thieves | Matthew 27:27–56; John 19:16–37 |

## 2. Christ Died, Was Buried, and Rose Again

Christ dies for our sins according to the **scriptures**. Joseph of Arimathaea places His body in a known tomb. On the **third** day the tomb is empty, and Jesus appears bodily to many named witnesses. The Gospel declared in this age is Christ's death for our sins, burial, and resurrection, and salvation is found in Him alone (1 Corinthians 15:1–4; Acts 4:12; Romans 1:16).

- The cross was foretold centuries earlier in Psalm 22 and Isaiah 53.
- Like the Passover lamb (Lesson 7), Jesus was without blemish, and His blood saves all who trust Him (1 Peter 1:18–19).
- The serpent bruised His heel at the cross, but by rising again Christ crushed the serpent's head (Genesis 3:15; Hebrews 2:14).

> **Isaiah 53:5 —** *But he was wounded for our transgressions, he was bruised for our iniquities: the chastisement of our peace was upon him; and with his stripes we are healed.*
>
> **Matthew 28:6 —** *He is not here: for he is risen, as he said. Come, see the place where the Lord lay.*

### Resurrection Witnesses

| Witness | Passage |
|---|---|
| Mary Magdalene and other women | Matthew 28:1–10; John 20:1–18 |
| Two disciples on the Emmaus road | Luke 24:13–35 |
| The gathered disciples | Luke 24:36–49; John 20:19–29 |
| More than five hundred brethren | 1 Corinthians 15:6 |
| James, the apostles, and Paul | 1 Corinthians 15:7–8 |

## 3. The Apostles Are Sent

The risen Christ commands His followers to teach all nations and preach the Gospel to every **creature**, as witnesses in the power of the Holy Ghost. Forty days after His resurrection He ascends to heaven, and the angels promise He will return in like **manner**.

- Jesus told them to wait in Jerusalem until the Holy Ghost came (Acts 1:4–5). That happens at Pentecost in the next lesson.
- The disciples asked if He would now restore the kingdom to Israel. Jesus did not say "never"; He said the timing belongs to the Father (Acts 1:6–7).
- The story now moves from the Gospels into the book of Acts.

> **Mark 16:15 —** *And he said unto them, Go ye into all the world, and preach the gospel to every creature.*
>
> **Acts 1:11 —** *...this same Jesus, which is taken up from you into heaven, shall so come in like manner as ye have seen him go into heaven.*

## Check Your Understanding

1. How did the triumphal entry identify Jesus?
2. Who was involved in Christ's rejection and condemnation?
3. What did Christ accomplish at the cross?
4. What evidence supports the bodily resurrection?
5. What did Jesus command the apostles to do?

UNIT 7 — THE CHURCH AND THE COMPLETION OF GOD'S PLAN

# Lesson 18 — Peter, Stephen, Philip, and Paul: The Gospel Goes to the Nations

**Lesson Overview:** The Holy Ghost comes at Pentecost, Peter proclaims the risen Christ, persecution scatters witnesses, Philip preaches in Samaria and to the Ethiopian, and Paul carries the Gospel through the Roman world while churches are established and taught.

**MAIN PASSAGES:** Acts 1–28; Romans 1:16–17; 1 Corinthians 15:1–4; Ephesians 2–3; Romans 9–11

**KEY VERSE | Acts 1:8 —** *But ye shall receive power, after that the Holy Ghost is come upon you: and ye shall be witnesses unto me...unto the uttermost part of the earth.*

**READ:** Acts 1–2; 4; 6–11; 13–21; 22–28; Romans 1:14–17; 3:21–28; 9–11; 1 Corinthians 12; Ephesians 2–3.

## The Story in Scripture

| Story movement | Scripture |
|---|---|
| The Holy Ghost comes | Acts 2. |
| Peter preaches Christ | Acts 2–5. |
| Stephen is martyred | Acts 6–7. |
| Philip preaches in Samaria and to the Ethiopian | Acts 8. |

| Story movement | Scripture |
|---|---|
| Saul meets the risen Christ | Acts 9. |
| Peter enters Cornelius's house | Acts 10–11. |
| Antioch sends Barnabas and Saul | Acts 13. |
| Paul's witness reaches Rome | Acts 13–28. |

## 1. Peter and the Jerusalem Witness

About ten days after Jesus ascends, the Holy Ghost comes on the day of **Pentecost**. Peter preaches the crucified and risen Christ, and about three thousand who receive the word are baptized and added to the church. Acts 1–7 centers on the witness to Israel in Jerusalem and ends with Stephen's rejection and death.

- Remember, Jesus told the apostles to wait in Jerusalem for the Holy Ghost (Lesson 17). Pentecost is the fulfillment.
- Peter, who had denied Jesus three times, now boldly preaches in the same city.
- Stephen is stoned for his witness, and a young man named Saul watches and approves (Acts 7:58; 8:1).

**Acts 2:41** — *Then they that gladly received his word were baptized: and the same day there were added unto them about three thousand souls.*

**Acts 2:42** — *And they continued stedfastly in the apostles' doctrine and fellowship, and in breaking of bread, and in prayers.*

## 2. Philip, Peter, and the Gentile Door

After Stephen's death, persecution scatters the believers into Judaea and Samaria, and they preach the word wherever they go. Philip preaches Christ from Isaiah 53 to the Ethiopian eunuch. Peter preaches in the house of **Cornelius**, a Roman centurion, and Gentiles receive the Word of God.

- Persecution was meant to stop the Gospel, but it spread it instead, following the pattern of Acts 1:8: Jerusalem, Judaea, Samaria, and the uttermost part of the earth.
- Cornelius was a Gentile. God showed Peter in a vision that the Gospel was for the nations too (Acts 10:28, 34–35).
- Remember, God promised Abraham that all families of the earth would be blessed through his seed (Lesson 4). Now it is happening.

**Acts 8:35 —** *Then Philip opened his mouth, and began at the same scripture, and preached unto him Jesus.*

**Acts 10:44 —** *While Peter yet spake these words, the Holy Ghost fell on all them which heard the word.*

## 3. Paul and the Missionary Churches

Saul, who persecuted the church, meets the risen Jesus on the road to Damascus and becomes Paul, the apostle to the Gentiles. The church at **Antioch** sends out Barnabas and Saul. Paul plants churches, defends the Gospel, writes epistles, and witnesses before rulers until Acts ends with him preaching in **Rome**.

- Paul wrote thirteen of the New Testament letters (Romans through Philemon), many of them to churches he started.
- Paul's usual pattern was to preach “to the Jew first, and also to the Greek” (Romans 1:16).
- Use the charts below to trace his journeys.

**Acts 9:15 —** *...for he is a chosen vessel unto me, to bear my name before the Gentiles, and kings, and the children of Israel:*

**Acts 13:2 —** *As they ministered to the Lord, and fasted, the Holy Ghost said, Separate me Barnabas and Saul for the work whereunto I have called them.*

### The Three Main Movements of Acts

| Chapters | Main movement | Key people and places |
|---|---|---|
| Acts 1–7 | Witness to Israel centered in Jerusalem | Peter, John, Stephen; Jerusalem |
| Acts 8–20 | Witness spreads outward; Gentiles receive the Word; churches are established | Philip, Peter, Paul, Barnabas; Samaria, Caesarea, Antioch, Asia, Macedonia, Achaia |
| Acts 21–28 | Paul is arrested, appeals to Caesar, and witnesses toward Rome | Paul; Jerusalem, Caesarea, Malta, Rome |

### Paul's Missionary Movement

| Journey / stage | Main regions | Acts |
|---|---|---|
| First journey | Cyprus and southern Galatia | Acts 13–14 |
| Jerusalem council | Jerusalem | Acts 15:1–35 |
| Second journey | Macedonia and Achaia | Acts 15:36–18:22 |
| Third journey | Ephesus, Macedonia, and Greece | Acts 18:23–21:17 |
| To Rome | Arrest, hearings, voyage, and Roman witness | Acts 21:18–28:31 |

## 4. Israel and the Church Remain Distinct

Believing Jews and Gentiles serve Christ together in this age, but the Church does not replace **Israel** or cancel Israel's land, throne, and national-restoration promises. Romans 11 says Israel's present blindness is partial and temporary and that God has not cast away His people.

- Remember, God made unconditional promises to Abraham (land, seed, blessing) and to David (throne, kingdom). God does not break His promises.
- In this age God is visiting the Gentiles "to take out of them a people for his name" (Acts 15:14).
- "Blindness in part is happened to Israel, until the fulness of the Gentiles be come in" (Romans 11:25). After that, Israel will be restored, which is where Revelation picks up (next lesson).

> **Romans 11:1 —** *I say then, Hath God cast away his people? God forbid...*
>
> **Romans 11:26 —** *And so all Israel shall be saved: as it is written, There shall come out of Sion the Deliverer, and shall turn away ungodliness from Jacob:*

### Israel and the Church in the Story

| Question | Israel | Church |
|---|---|---|
| Beginning | Abraham, Isaac, Jacob; called out of Egypt as a nation | Promised by Christ; formed after the Holy Ghost came at Pentecost |
| Identity | The nation descended from Jacob / Israel | Believing Jews and Gentiles serving Christ; expressed through local churches |
| Primary calling | Literal nation connected with promised land and throne | Heavenly calling with a present Gospel mission among all nations |

| Question | Israel | Church |
|---|---|---|
| Present | Partly blinded and set aside nationally, but not cast away | Witnessing, teaching, and serving while waiting for Christ |
| Future | National turning, regathering, land, and Davidic kingdom | Gathered to Christ before the Tribulation; returns and reigns with Him |
| Key passages | Genesis 12; 15; 17; 2 Samuel 7; Ezekiel 36–37; Romans 11 | Matthew 16:18; Acts 2; Ephesians 2–3; 1 Thessalonians 4 |

## Check Your Understanding

1. What did Peter preach at Pentecost?
2. How did Stephen's death change the movement of Acts?
3. How did Philip and Peter help open the Gentile mission?
4. Trace Paul's witness from Antioch to Rome.
5. How does Romans 11 preserve Israel's future?

UNIT 7 — THE CHURCH AND THE COMPLETION OF GOD'S PLAN

# Lesson 19 — John's Revelation: Christ Returns and Makes All Things New

**Lesson Overview:** John sees the risen Christ, Christ's messages to the churches, the judgments of the Tribulation, the visible return of the King, the thousand-year kingdom, Satan's final defeat, the Great White Throne, and eternity in the new creation.

**MAIN PASSAGES:** John 14:1–3; 1 Corinthians 15:51–58; 1 Thessalonians 4:13–18; Daniel 9:24–27; Revelation 1–22

**KEY VERSE | Revelation 21:3 —** *Behold, the tabernacle of God is with men, and he will dwell with them, and they shall be his people…*

**READ:** John 14:1–3; 1 Corinthians 3:11–15; 15:51–58; 1 Thessalonians 4:13–5:11; Daniel 9:24–27; Revelation 1–3; 6–22; 2 Peter 3:10–13.

## The Story in Scripture

| Story movement | Scripture |
|---|---|
| John sees the risen Christ | Revelation 1. |
| Christ addresses seven churches | Revelation 2–3. |
| Christ gathers His Church | John 14:1–3; 1 Thessalonians 4:13–18. |
| Tribulation judgments unfold | Daniel 9:24–27; Revelation 6–18. |

| Story movement | Scripture |
|---|---|
| Christ returns as King | Revelation 19:11–21. |
| Christ reigns one thousand years | Revelation 20:1–6. |
| Satan is defeated and the dead are judged | Revelation 20:7–15. |
| God makes all things new | Revelation 21–22. |

## 1. Christ and the Churches

The apostle John, exiled on the isle of **Patmos**, sees Jesus Christ glorified and hears His messages to seven literal churches. Their order also gives a broad spiritual picture from early zeal through persecution, compromise, reform, missionary opportunity, and final decline. The last church, Laodicea, is described as **lukewarm**.

- Remember, Jesus ascended and promised to return (Lesson 17). Revelation shows how the story ends.
- John was the last living apostle, the same John who wrote the Gospel of John and 1–3 John.
- Revelation 1:19 gives the outline of the book: what John had seen, "the things which are" (the churches), and "the things which shall be hereafter."

**Revelation 1:9 —** *I John, who also am your brother, and companion in tribulation... was in the isle that is called Patmos, for the word of God, and for the testimony of Jesus Christ.*

**Revelation 3:16 —** *So then because thou art lukewarm, and neither cold nor hot, I will spue thee out of my mouth.*

### The Seven Churches of Revelation 2–3

| Church | Christ's main message | Spiritual picture |
|---|---|---|
| Ephesus | Sound labor, but first love left | Early strength with declining love |
| Smyrna | Faithful through suffering | Persecuted church |
| Pergamos | Faithfulness mixed with false doctrine | Worldly alliance and compromise |
| Thyatira | Service mixed with deep corruption | Growing religious corruption |
| Sardis | A name to live, but spiritually dead | Formal profession needing revival |
| Philadelphia | An open door and faithful Word | Missionary opportunity and faithfulness |
| Laodicea | Lukewarm, self-satisfied, and poor | Final apostasy and self-sufficiency |

## 2. The Rapture, Judgment Seat, and Tribulation

Christ will descend from heaven, the dead in Christ will rise, and living believers will be caught up to meet Him in the **air**. This comes before the Tribulation and is different from Christ's public return. Believers' service is evaluated at the judgment seat of Christ. Daniel's seventieth week concerns Daniel's people and holy city. During the Tribulation the Antichrist rises, judgment falls, and Israel is brought through trouble toward national repentance.

- Remember, Daniel was shown God's plan for Israel in “seventy weeks” (Daniel 9:24–27). Sixty-nine were completed up to the Messiah; the last “week” of seven years is still future. That is the Tribulation.

- The Church is promised deliverance “from the wrath to come” (1 Thessalonians 1:10).
- The judgment seat of Christ is not about salvation. It is about rewards for believers' service (1 Corinthians 3:11–15).

> **1 Thessalonians 4:16–17 —** *For the Lord himself shall descend from heaven with a shout, with the voice of the archangel, and with the trump of God: and the dead in Christ shall rise first: Then we which are alive and remain shall be caught up together with them in the clouds, to meet the Lord in the air: and so shall we ever be with the Lord.*

### The Rapture and Second Coming Distinguished

| Question | Rapture | Second Coming |
|---|---|---|
| Christ's movement | Believers meet Christ in the air | Christ returns openly to earth |
| People emphasized | Dead in Christ and living believers | Israel and the nations; saints return with Christ |
| Purpose | Gather the Church to Christ | Judge enemies, deliver Israel, establish the kingdom |
| Timing | Before the Tribulation | After the Tribulation |
| Passages | John 14:1–3; 1 Corinthians 15:51–58; 1 Thessalonians 4:13–18 | Zechariah 12–14; Matthew 24:29–31; Revelation 19:11–21 |

## 3. The King Returns and Reigns

Jesus Christ returns visibly as King of kings, defeats His enemies, delivers Israel's believing remnant, and sets up the promised Davidic kingdom. Satan is bound while Christ reigns on earth for one thousand **years**. After the thousand years Satan leads a final rebellion and is cast into the lake of fire. Then the unsaved dead are judged at the Great White **Throne**.

- Remember, God promised David a King and a kingdom that would last forever (Lesson 12). This is when that promise is seen on earth.
- Remember, God promised Abraham the land (Lesson 4). In the kingdom, Israel will finally possess it in peace.
- Satan, the rebel from Lesson 1, meets his final end, just as Genesis 3:15 promised.

**Revelation 19:16 —** *And he hath on his vesture and on his thigh a name written, KING OF KINGS, AND LORD OF LORDS.*

**Revelation 20:10 —** *And the devil that deceived them was cast into the lake of fire and brimstone, where the beast and the false prophet are, and shall be tormented day and night for ever and ever.*

### From Christ's Return to Final Judgment

| Event | What happens | Scripture |
|---|---|---|
| Second Coming | Christ returns openly as King of kings | Revelation 19:11–21 |
| Satan bound | The deceiver is confined for one thousand years | Revelation 20:1–3 |
| Millennium | Christ reigns; Israel's kingdom promises are fulfilled | Isaiah 11; Ezekiel 36–37; Revelation 20:4–6 |
| Final rebellion | Satan is released and leads one last revolt | Revelation 20:7–10 |
| Great White Throne | The unsaved dead are judged according to the books | Revelation 20:11–15 |

## 4. New Creation and Eternity

God makes a new heaven and a new earth. New Jerusalem comes down, there is no more **curse**, and God's servants see His face and serve Him. The story that began with rebellion, darkness, and a lost garden ends with Christ victorious and God dwelling with His people.

- Look at the chart below: what was lost in Genesis is restored in Revelation.
- The tree of life, guarded after Adam's sin (Lesson 2), is open again (Revelation 22:2).
- The whole Bible is one story: God keeping His promises through His King, Jesus Christ.

> **Revelation 22:3** — *And there shall be no more curse: but the throne of God and of the Lamb shall be in it; and his servants shall serve him:*
>
> **Revelation 22:20** — *...Surely I come quickly. Amen. Even so, come, Lord Jesus.*

### The Bible Story Completed

| Beginning | Completion | Scripture |
|---|---|---|
| Heaven and earth created | New heaven and new earth | Genesis 1:1; Revelation 21:1 |
| Darkness and rebellion | No night and no more rebellion | Genesis 1:2; Revelation 21:23–27; 22:5 |
| Tree of life guarded | Tree of life freely available | Genesis 3:22–24; Revelation 22:2, 14 |
| Curse enters | No more curse | Genesis 3:14–19; Revelation 22:3 |
| Man driven from God's presence | God dwells with His people | Genesis 3:23–24; Revelation 21:3 |

| Beginning | Completion | Scripture |
| --- | --- | --- |
| Serpent promised defeat | Satan in the lake of fire | Genesis 3:15; Revelation 20:10 |

## Check Your Understanding

1. What do Christ's messages to the seven churches teach?
2. How is the Rapture distinct from the Second Coming?
3. How do Daniel 9 and Revelation describe the Tribulation?
4. What happens during and after the thousand-year kingdom?
5. How do Revelation 21–22 complete the story begun in Genesis?

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# Appendix A — The Sixty-Six Books and Their Place in the Story

Each book belongs to a major division and contributes to the Bible's connected history.

| Division | Book | Role in the story |
|---|---|---|
| Law | Genesis | Beginnings; patriarchs; covenant promise |
| Law | Exodus | Israel redeemed from Egypt and formed as a nation |
| Law | Leviticus | Holiness, priesthood, sacrifices, worship |
| Law | Numbers | Wilderness testing and the new generation |
| Law | Deuteronomy | Covenant instruction renewed before Canaan |
| History | Joshua | Conquest and distribution of the land |
| History | Judges | Cycles of apostasy, oppression, and deliverance |
| History | Ruth | Kinsman redemption and David's family line |
| History | 1 Samuel | Samuel, Saul, and David's rise |
| History | 2 Samuel | David's reign and covenant |
| History | 1 Kings | Solomon and the divided kingdom begins |
| History | 2 Kings | Both kingdoms decline and go into exile |
| History | 1 Chronicles | Genealogies and David with temple emphasis |
| History | 2 Chronicles | Solomon and Judah with temple emphasis |
| History | Ezra | Return and rebuilding of the temple |
| History | Nehemiah | Jerusalem's walls and covenant renewal |

| Division | Book | Role in the story |
|---|---|---|
| History | Esther | Providential preservation in Persia |
| Poetry/Wisdom | Job | Suffering, human limits, and God's wisdom |
| Poetry/Wisdom | Psalms | Inspired worship, prayer, and Messianic hope |
| Poetry/Wisdom | Proverbs | Wisdom under the fear of the LORD |
| Poetry/Wisdom | Ecclesiastes | Life under the sun and the whole duty of man |
| Poetry/Wisdom | Song of Solomon | Covenant love in marriage poetry |
| Major Prophets | Isaiah | Judgment, comfort, Servant, and Messianic King |
| Major Prophets | Jeremiah | Judah's last days and new-covenant promise |
| Major Prophets | Lamentations | Mourning Jerusalem's destruction |
| Major Prophets | Ezekiel | Glory, exile, new heart, restoration, temple |
| Major Prophets | Daniel | Faithful witness and the course of kingdoms |
| Minor Prophets | Hosea | Israel's unfaithfulness and God's covenant love |
| Minor Prophets | Joel | The day of the LORD and promised Spirit |
| Minor Prophets | Amos | Justice, judgment, and Davidic restoration |
| Minor Prophets | Obadiah | Edom judged; the kingdom belongs to the LORD |
| Minor Prophets | Jonah | God's mercy to Nineveh and a reluctant prophet |
| Minor Prophets | Micah | Judgment, Bethlehem's ruler, and restoration |
| Minor Prophets | Nahum | Nineveh's final judgment |
| Minor Prophets | Habakkuk | Questions, faith, and God's sovereign justice |
| Minor Prophets | Zephaniah | The day of the LORD and a restored remnant |

| Division | Book | Role in the story |
|---|---|---|
| Minor Prophets | Haggai | Rebuild the temple; future glory |
| Minor Prophets | Zechariah | Visions, the Branch, the pierced King, the kingdom |
| Minor Prophets | Malachi | Corrupt worship and the coming messenger |
| Gospels | Matthew | Jesus the Messiah and King |
| Gospels | Mark | Jesus the authoritative Servant |
| Gospels | Luke | Jesus the perfect Son of man and Saviour |
| Gospels | John | Jesus the divine Son who gives life |
| History | Acts | The Spirit-empowered witness from Jerusalem to Rome |
| Epistles | Romans | The gospel, justification, sanctification, Israel |
| Epistles | 1 Corinthians | Church correction, gifts, resurrection |
| Epistles | 2 Corinthians | Ministry, weakness, comfort, giving |
| Epistles | Galatians | Justification by faith apart from the Law |
| Epistles | Ephesians | The Church in Christ and one new body |
| Epistles | Philippians | Joy, humility, and Christ-centered living |
| Epistles | Colossians | The supremacy and sufficiency of Christ |
| Epistles | 1 Thessalonians | A model church and Christ's return |
| Epistles | 2 Thessalonians | The day of the Lord and steadfastness |
| Epistles | 1 Timothy | Doctrine, leadership, and church order |
| Epistles | 2 Timothy | Guard and pass on the Word |

| Division | Book | Role in the story |
|---|---|---|
| Epistles | Titus | Sound doctrine and good works |
| Epistles | Philemon | Gospel reconciliation in a personal case |
| General Epistles | Hebrews | Christ better than the old-covenant shadows |
| General Epistles | James | Living faith shown through works |
| General Epistles | 1 Peter | Hope and holiness in suffering |
| General Epistles | 2 Peter | Growth, Scripture, false teachers, coming day |
| General Epistles | 1 John | Assurance, truth, obedience, and love |
| General Epistles | 2 John | Truth and love with discernment |
| General Epistles | 3 John | Faithful hospitality and harmful ambition |
| General Epistles | Jude | Contend for the faith against apostasy |
| General Epistles | Revelation | Christ's victory, judgment, kingdom, and new creation |

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# Appendix B — Key Bible-Story Terms

Read each term according to its immediate biblical context.

| Term | Definition |
|---|---|
| Covenant | A binding promise or agreement established by God; always identify its parties and terms. |
| Dispensation / stewardship | An order of responsibility entrusted by God for a particular period (Ephesians 3:2; Colossians 1:25). |
| Gentile | A person or nation outside Israel. |
| Hebrew | A name first used of Abram and later of his descendants. |
| Israel | Jacob's God-given name and the name of the nation descended from him; after the split it can also mean the northern kingdom. |
| Jew | A name connected with Judah and commonly used for Israel's people after the exile and in the New Testament. |
| Church | An assembly belonging to Christ; Acts and the Epistles show local churches carrying out His commands. |
| Kingdom of Heaven | Heaven's visible rule on earth through Israel's promised King. |
| Kingdom of God | God's spiritual rule, marked by righteousness, peace, and joy in the Holy Ghost. |
| Day of the LORD / Day of Jesus Christ | The Day of the LORD concerns God's intervention in judgment and Christ's public return; the Day of Jesus Christ concerns Christ's gathering of believers and the completion of His work in the Church. |

| Term | Definition |
| --- | --- |
| Messiah / Christ | The Anointed One promised in the Old Testament and revealed as Jesus. |
| Gospel | The good news that Christ died for our sins, was buried, and rose again the third day (1 Corinthians 15:1–4). |
| Rapture | Christ's gathering of the dead in Christ and living believers to meet Him in the air. |
| Tribulation | Daniel's final week and the time of judgment preceding Christ's public return. |
| Second Coming | Christ's visible return to earth as King of kings. |
| Millennium | Christ's literal thousand-year reign described in Revelation 20. |

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# Appendix C — Kings and Prophets Master Reference

Kings and prophets belong to the same history. These tables connect the rulers, prophetic ministries, and national outcomes.

## Northern Kingdom — Selected Kings and Prophets

| Period | Selected kings | Prophets and message | Outcome / study |
|---|---|---|---|
| First dynasty | Jeroboam I, Nadab | A man of God condemns the altar | Counterfeit worship begins (1 Kings 12–14) |
| Baasha to Omri | Baasha, Elah, Zimri, Omri | Jehu son of Hanani warns Baasha | Dynasties change through violence (1 Kings 15–16) |
| House of Omri | Ahab, Ahaziah, Joram | Elijah and Elisha confront Baal | Drought, Carmel, signs, judgment (1 Kings 17–2 Kings 9) |
| House of Jehu | Jehu, Jehoahaz, Joash, Jeroboam II | Jonah, Amos, Hosea | Temporary strength; deep corruption (2 Kings 10–14) |
| Final years | Zechariah, Shallum, Menahem, Pekahiah, Pekah, Hoshea | Warnings continue, but Israel will not hear | Samaria falls to Assyria (2 Kings 15–17) |

## Southern Kingdom — Selected Kings and Prophets

| Period | Selected rulers | Prophets and message | Outcome / study |
|---|---|---|---|
| Early kingdom | Rehoboam, Abijah, Asa, Jehoshaphat | Shemaiah, Azariah, Hanani, Jehu | Compromise and reform (2 Chronicles 10–20) |
| Athaliah crisis | Jehoram, Ahaziah, Athaliah, Joash | Elijah's letter; Jehoiada and Zechariah | David's line preserved (2 Chronicles 21–24) |
| Assyrian era | Amaziah, Uzziah, Jotham, Ahaz, Hezekiah | Isaiah, Micah, Hosea | Jerusalem delivered from Assyria (2 Kings 18–20) |
| Final reform | Manasseh, Amon, Josiah | Nahum, Zephaniah, Jeremiah | Josiah responds to the Law (2 Kings 21–23) |
| Final kings | Jehoahaz, Jehoiakim, Jehoiachin, Zedekiah | Jeremiah, Habakkuk, Ezekiel | Jerusalem falls to Babylon (2 Kings 24–25) |

### Prophets in their historical settings

| Period | Audience | Prophets | Primary emphasis |
|---|---|---|---|
| Divided kingdom—early | Judah/Israel | Shemaiah, Ahijah, Hanani, Jehu son of Hanani | Division, covenant warning, royal accountability |
| Ahab/Omri dynasty | Israel | Elijah, Micaiah, Elisha | Baal confronted; the LORD alone is God |
| Jeroboam II and after | Israel | Jonah, Amos, Hosea | Prosperity cannot hide injustice and apostasy |
| Assyrian crisis | Judah | Isaiah, Micah | Trust the LORD; judgment and Messianic hope |

| Period | Audience | Prophets | Primary emphasis |
|---|---|---|---|
| Josiah/final kings | Judah | Zephaniah, Habakkuk, Jeremiah, Huldah | Day of the LORD; Babylon coming; return promised |
| Babylonian exile | Exiles/ Gentile courts | Ezekiel, Daniel | Glory, responsibility, empires, restoration |
| Return and rebuilding | Returned community | Haggai, Zechariah | Rebuild; the Branch and coming King |
| Post-exilic decline | Judah | Malachi | Pure worship; coming messenger and Lord |

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# Appendix D — Selected Messianic Prophecies and Fulfillments

These Old Testament promises are paired with their New Testament fulfillment or inspired explanation. Some passages also include future kingdom elements beyond Christ's first coming.

| Promise | Old Testament | New Testament | Significance |
|---|---|---|---|
| Seed of the woman | Genesis 3:15 | Galatians 4:4; Hebrews 2:14 | Human birth and victory over the serpent |
| Blessing through Abraham's seed | Genesis 12:3; 22:18 | Galatians 3:8, 16 | Gospel blessing reaches the nations |
| Ruler from Judah | Genesis 49:10 | Luke 3:33; Revelation 5:5 | Messiah comes from Judah |
| Prophet like Moses | Deuteronomy 18:15–18 | Acts 3:20–23 | Authoritative Prophet must be heard |
| Son and throne of David | 2 Samuel 7:12–16 | Luke 1:32–33 | Everlasting Davidic King |
| Resurrection / no corruption | Psalm 16:10 | Acts 2:25–32; 13:35–37 | Christ rises from the dead |
| Suffering described | Psalm 22 | Matthew 27; John 19 | Mocking, pierced suffering, garments divided |
| Virgin-born Immanuel | Isaiah 7:14 | Matthew 1:22–23 | God with us |

| Promise | Old Testament | New Testament | Significance |
|---|---|---|---|
| Divine Davidic ruler | Isaiah 9:6–7 | Luke 1:32–35 | Son given; everlasting government |
| Forerunner's voice | Isaiah 40:3 | Matthew 3:1–3 | John prepares the Lord's way |
| Sin-bearing Servant | Isaiah 52:13–53:12 | Acts 8:30–35; 1 Peter 2:24 | Substitution, death, burial, vindication |
| New covenant | Jeremiah 31:31–34 | Luke 22:20; Hebrews 8 | Promised to Israel and Judah; ratified by Christ's blood |
| Ruler born in Bethlehem | Micah 5:2 | Matthew 2:5–6 | David's city and ancient goings forth |
| Humble King enters Jerusalem | Zechariah 9:9 | Matthew 21:4–9 | Royal entry on an ass |
| Pierced One | Zechariah 12:10 | John 19:37; Revelation 1:7 | Piercing and future recognition |
| Coming messenger | Malachi 3:1; 4:5–6 | Luke 1:16–17; Mark 1:2–4 | John ministers in Elijah's spirit and power |